

The Pioneer
Classified

CHANGE OF NAME

Krishna Gopal Saraswat S/O
Angali Ram Saraswat R/O 427,
Tarane, District- Agra- 283101
Pradesh, declare that
Krishna Gopal Saraswat &
Krishna Gopal Saraswat both are
the same and one person and
presently and future I will be
known with the name of Krishna
Gopal Saraswat.

PD(1277)C

Keshav S/o Kuldeep Saini
Rawla R/o A-1-T, Delhi Police
Department, MayurVihar Phase-
East Delhi-110091 have
changed my name to Keshav
Rawla S/o Kuldeep Saini
Rawla for all future purposes.

PD(1278)C

Hitherto known as chaturbhuj
S/o Balwant Lal R/o H.No-154,
Block, street No 02, west,
Kamla vihar, Karawal Nagar, PO-
Mayapalpur, DIST- North east,
Delhi-110094, have changed my
name and shall hereafter be
known as chaturbhuj singh for
future purposes.

PD(1289)C

Roof exit blocked, cooking heaters found in fire-hit hotel rooms: Police

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police on Thursday inspected the fire-damaged hotel in Malviya Nagar. Officers found that the roof exit was blocked and cooking heaters were present in several guest rooms.

These findings are now central to the investigation into the incident, which left 21 dead. After the inspection, police formed five teams to trace and arrest the absconding manager, Jai Mishra.

Officials said investigators are examining possible violations of building regulations. They are also looking into fire safety lapses and unauthorised construction.

Authorities are reviewing the bed-and-breakfast's ownership. Investigators are assessing what led to the high number of deaths.

A police officer said, "We are questioning locals, shopkeepers, hotel staff, and other witnesses as part of the investigation."

Police have issued a Look Out Circular (LOC) for hotel owner Lavkesh Bajaj and his wife due to concerns they may attempt to leave the country. Bajaj was arrested on Wednesday night. LOC was opened as a precautionary measure even after his arrest, a police official said.

Bajaj told police that he had transferred hotel management and obtained all related licenses in Mishra's name.

Police sources indicated that Bajaj was the actual owner, with the 'bed-and-breakfast' license obtained in Jai Mishra's name.

The fire broke out on Wednesday morning at Flourish Stay B&B. Twenty-



A forensic team is present at the scene following a fire in a five-story building in south Delhi's Malviya Nagar area on Thursday

one people died, many of them foreign nationals, and dozens were injured. Investigators said blocked roof access may have stopped people from escaping as smoke filled the five-storey building.

The use of cooking heaters in several rooms is under review. Officials said the CFSL team will return to the site for

a detailed examination to determine the cause of the fire.

Police are searching for a key eyewitness, Kesar Singh, whose statement is important for establishing how the fire started and spread. Investigators have found alleged large-scale operational violations at the property. Bajaj bought the property from Ahluwalia in 2022, when it had 2.5 floors.

He later added more floors, making it nearly five storeys. Police believe Bajaj may try to leave the country, as both his children live abroad.

Police sources said Bajaj first rented rooms and got a license for a tea shop. He later converted the property into a bed-and-breakfast, which operated beyond its permitted use.

Sources said that in 2022, Bajaj hired Mishra, a former

accountant, to manage daily operations and accounts. This move formalised the distinction between ownership and management.

The establishment was authorised to operate six rooms, but allegedly used about 25 rooms, including some in the basement. This is one of the main violations under investigation.

Officials said mandatory fire safety clearance was missing. The building also allegedly exceeded the height limit, both requiring certification from Delhi Fire Services.

The structure included a restaurant on the ground floor and guest accommodation in the basement and upper floors.

The entry-exit point and a sensor-operated main door hindered evacuation efforts. The owner, Lavkesh Bajaj, and investigators are review-

ing claims that sealed windows, a single entry-exit point, and a sensor-operated main door hindered evacuation efforts.

Police have charged owner Lavkesh Bajaj with culpable homicide. Additional charges include sections 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), 326(g) (mischief by fire), 324(5) (wrongful damage of property), 125(a) (negligent act endangering life), 125(b) (grievous hurt by negligence), and 287 BNS (negligent conduct with respect to fire).

Police officials involved in the investigation said, "We will examine the roles of all individuals involved in the property's ownership, management, and licensing." They will follow formalities to ensure proper identification. The cause of the fire remains under investigation.

Malviya Nagar B&B had no fire NOC, one exit, unauthorised cylinders

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi

The devastating fire that broke out at the Flourish Stay 'bed-and-breakfast' in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani area around 6.30 am on Wednesday has exposed possible safety lapses, illegal building expansions, and fire safety violations.

Twenty-one people died, most of them foreign nationals visiting for medical treatment. At least 20 others were hospitalised, including 17 foreigners.

Investigators said the hotel was licensed for only 6 rooms under Delhi's B&B policy, but was operating 25 rooms across all floors, far above the allowed limit.

The five-storey building lacked a fire safety NOC and had only one narrow stairway for entry and exit.

The stairway's sensor-operated door failed during the emergency. Sealed windows prevented escape, there were no emergency

exits or proper evacuation routes, and the roof exit was blocked. Portable cooking heaters were also found in guest rooms, which increased the fire risk.

The fire reportedly started on the ground floor. The fire is believed to have started in the Lemon Green restaurant on the ground floor, which did not have an authorised gas connection. Police found four commercial gas cylinders at the scene and suspect they were used illegally, possibly causing the fire.

The restaurant staff left the premises, and investigators are looking for them. Vijay Kumar presented details of the investigation while addressing the media.

He stated: "The operations permit allowed only 6 rooms, but the facility had 25 rooms in use. A restaurant operated on the ground floor without an authorised gas connection, and four gas cylinders were found on the premises, indicating



their use. The restaurant staff have left the premises, and we are gathering information on their whereabouts." He confirmed that relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita have been invoked, specifically Section 105 (culpable homicide not amounting to murder), along with provisions covering negligent acts endangering life, mischief by fire, and negligent conduct regarding fire. Kumar added, "Relevant legal provisions have been applied," and reported that the investigation began the previous day.

Owner Lavkesh Bajaj (60) who lives in Saket and runs several hospitality businesses, was arrested late Wednesday after allegedly trying to avoid the police.

During questioning, he admitted to making illegal expansions for profit and reportedly said, "Delhi mein sab chalta hai" (everything works in Delhi). Sources said Bajaj drove past the burning building but did not stop to help, later saying he was afraid. He is in police custody for four days, and authorities say he has not cooperated with the investigation.

Two of Bajaj's other nearby properties are also being checked for similar violations and have been sealed. An earlier FIR was reportedly filed against this building in 2024 for breaking codes. This situation raises questions about how civic agencies like the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD), the fire department, and the electricity board monitor compliance with regulations.

The incident has led to public concern regarding safety and regulatory systems. Opposition leaders have raised questions about the reported delay in fire tenders reaching the congested area where the incident occurred.

Trade bodies have called for a comprehensive safety audit of hotels and restaurants across Delhi and accountability for officials involved. The Delhi government has announced ex gratia payments of ₹10 lakh for the families of the deceased and ₹5 lakh for the

seriously injured.

The government has also ordered further action regarding unauthorised commercial establishments in Delhi's South Zone.

Most of the victims were medical tourists from countries like Liberia, Nigeria, Mozambique, Bangladesh, and Turkmenistan. An Indian family of eight from Gurugram, who were visiting a patient at a nearby hospital, was also among those who died.

At least eight patients are still in critical condition on ventilators at Max Hospital because of severe smoke inhalation and asphyxiation. Forensic teams are still examining the site as more details come out.

Police have set up several teams to find the missing restaurant staff and others under investigation. The case points to ongoing safety and compliance problems in the area. More arrests and action against officials are expected.

Hauz Rani falls silent after hotel fire as safety questions rise



KHUSHI MEHROTRA ■ New Delhi

A day after the catastrophic fire at Flourish Stay in Hauz Rani claimed 21 lives, the charred hotel remained sealed off on Thursday as residents questioned the safety norms governing the area's numerous budget hotels, and some foreign nationals began leaving the locality following the tragedy.

The narrow lane where the blaze broke out stood unusually quiet, with Delhi Police personnel deployed at every checkpoint leading to the burnt building. Forensic teams continued collecting evidence from the site throughout the afternoon.

Residents said the incident had shaken confidence in an area known for hosting foreign patients seeking affordable medical treatment in Delhi.

"Our area was known as a haven for people coming from abroad for treatment. This incident has tarnished that image," said a local woman. She pointed out that several hotels in the locality operate from narrow buildings with only a single entry and exit point. Following Wednesday's fire, authorities shut down many such establishments, leaving foreign visitors scrambling for accommodation.

A short distance from the burnt hotel, locals pointed to a white Audi parked along the lane. They said the vehicle belonged to Vivek Agarwal, one of the victims of the fire.

"Who will drive this now? He died yesterday," a resident remarked. Agarwal, a resident of Gurugram, was among seven members of the same family who lost their lives in the tragedy.

Just a short walk from the accident site, another branch of Flourish Inn stood deserted. *The Pioneer* found an Ethiopian national carrying luggage down the staircase. His family members remained admitted at Max Hospital in Saket for treatment, while he searched for alternative accommodation after the tragedy.

Near the burnt hotel, a couple from Kazakhstan who had escaped the blaze returned to search for passports and other documents. Locals said they had jumped from the building to save themselves. The man, with a bandaged hand, said he had been injured during the escape. An Iraqi Embassy representative also visited the site and confirmed that Iraqi nationals were among those affected. He said one Iraqi citizen died in the fire.

In the same lane as Flourish Stay, at least five similar multi-storey hotels remained shuttered on Thursday. At the same time, residents continued to raise concerns about fire safety and emergency exits in the densely packed neighbourhood. Delhi Police arrested the owner of Flourish Stay on Wednesday night in connection with the incident.

CM meets fire victims, announces ₹10 lakh ex gratia for kin of deceased

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday visited a hospital in Saket to meet people injured in the Malviya Nagar fire tragedy and announced financial assistance for the victims and their families, while ordering a detailed review of fire safety standards across the Capital. The Chief Minister said families of those who died in the incident would receive an ex gratia payment of ₹10 lakh each, while people who suffered serious injuries would be given financial assistance of ₹5 lakh.

During her visit to the hospital, the Chief Minister met injured patients undergoing treatment and spoke to their relatives about the condition of those admitted after the fire. She also held discus-

sions with doctors and hospital authorities regarding the treatment being provided to the victims.

The Chief Minister stated that some patients are in critical condition, while others have been placed on ventilator support. The affected individuals include citizens from various countries including Bangladesh, Nepal, Cameroon, and Libya in addition to those from India.

The Chief Minister directed officials to ensure that there was no delay or deficiency in medical care and said all injured persons must receive the best possible treatment. She instructed authorities to continuously monitor the condition of patients and provide all required support to affected families. "The Delhi Government stands firmly with every affected family during this difficult time," she said while interacting with patients and rela-

tives at the hospital.

Officials briefed the Chief Minister about the treatment status of individual patients and ongoing medical arrangements. The Chief Minister assured families that the government would provide every possible assistance for the recovery and rehabilitation of the victims.

The government also announced arrangements for transporting the mortal remains of deceased victims to their native places. The Chief Minister directed officials to ensure dignified transportation for families residing outside Delhi, including those living in other states or abroad.

During the hospital visit, the Chief Minister was informed about rescue efforts carried out during the fire incident. According to officials and family members present there, local residents, hotel staff,



Delhi CM Rekha Gupta meets a person injured in the Malviya Nagar fire incident, which claimed the lives of 21 people, at Max Hospital, Saket in New Delhi on Thursday

police personnel, and volunteers risked their lives to save people trapped inside the building.

Several injured persons were reportedly given emergency CPR and first aid at the scene before being shifted to hospitals. The Chief Minister praised the role of citizens

and emergency responders who participated in rescue operations during the crisis. She directed the administration to identify individuals who made significant contributions during the rescue efforts so they could be formally recognised and honoured by the government.

Foreigners vacate hotels on Press Enclave Road after deadly fire

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

On Thursday, foreign nationals and other guests vacated hotels and guest houses on Press Enclave Road following requests from several establishments, in the aftermath of a devastating fire at Malviya Nagar that resulted in the death of 21 individuals the previous day.

Due to the incident, some guest houses ceased providing food and cut electricity, compelling residents to seek alternative accommodation.



The neighbourhood, once known for its continuous activity and numerous hotels serving primarily visitors to

the nearby Max Hospital, was characterised by a climate of fear and uncertainty. Three establishments, the Flourish B&B, where the fire originated, the Florist Inn, and the Green Residency, are owned by Lovkesh Bajaj.

All three remained closed on Thursday, and several occupants were observed packing their belongings and departing.

Among those checking out was Jilbert from the Republic of Congo, who was staying at the Florist Inn.

He stated, Since yesterday,

there has been no food service, and there is no electricity. We are facing difficulties and are relocating. We will find alternative accommodation," she said.

Bilunga Mukasa, another foreign national residing in a guest house in the area for an extended period, noted that the incident had caused considerable anxiety among residents. People are frightened after the incident. Many guests have left, and some are seeking new accommodations due to safety concerns," he remarked.

Fire at closed cafe in Humayunpur basement, no injuries

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A fire broke out in the basement of a building in Delhi's Humayunpur village on Thursday evening. It was brought under control before it could spread to adjoining properties, officials said. No injuries were reported in the incident.

According to Delhi Police, a PCR call regarding the fire near the NCC Office and Jaat Chaupal in Humayunpur was received at the Safdarjung Enclave police



station at 7.03 pm personnel on patrol rushed to the scene and found flames emanating from the locked basement of the building.

Officials said the base-

ment had previously housed a cafe that was shut down about two to three months ago and was currently being used by the owner for storage.

With the assistance of residents, police personnel broke open the basement lock and a side wall to gain access to the premises.

They also arranged a water connection from nearby houses and managed to contain the blaze before the fire tenders arrived.

The Delhi Fire Services dispatched three water tenders, one water bowser and a breathing apparatus fire tender to the spot.

Fire officials declared that the blaze was under control at around 7.20 pm.

I have no material left in my shop: Mattress seller who became lifesaver

KHUSHI MEHROTRA
■ New Delhi

As flames engulfed the Flourish Inn hotel in Delhi's Malviya Nagar on Wednesday morning, 27-year-old Armaan Mansoori did not think twice before turning his small mattress and blanket shop into a rescue operation.

By the time the fire was brought under control, much of the stock in his roadside store had been used to save trapped guests desperate to escape the inferno. The shop is located directly opposite

the Flourish Inn hotel.

"I have no material left in my shop. We used everything to save people," Mansoori said on Thursday, standing outside the tin-shed store directly opposite the gutted hotel.

The shop, established by his father Riyazuddin in the 1990s, sells cotton mattresses and blankets sourced from Panipat and nearby areas. For the past three to four years, Armaan has been helping run the family business. Speaking about monetary losses, Mansoori believed that money would come back,

but those screaming for help were of utmost importance.

When smoke and flames began spreading through the building, Mansoori and dozens of residents rushed to help before emergency services could reach those trapped inside. Mansoori received a call from a friend who alerted him about the fire. He rushed to the spot and started rescuing the hotel guests before the multi-agency operation began. According to these local first responders, they saved close to 11-12 people.

"We didn't want anyone to



Aamir Khan, a resident of Hauz Rani village who suffered slight injuries while rescuing trapped hotel guests



Armaan Mansoori (27), runs the mattress store across Flourish Stay B&B along with his father



Armaan Mansoori's shop loaded with materials before the fire at Flourish Inn

die and did everything to save all," he said. Mansoori also mentioned that if he hadn't reached the spot in time, his shop could have been in the line of fire.

Using blankets and mattresses tied together, residents created makeshift rescue lines to bring people down from upper floors. According to Mansoori, some victims were considerably taller and heavier than the rescuers. "Even though some of the African people were taller than us, we used three to five blankets to bring them down safely," he

recalled.

The rescue, however, came at a high emotional cost.

"Our local people went up to three floors, and the scenes were unimaginable. They will probably stay in my memory forever," he said. "We saw people holding each other who had died. When we tried to help some victims, their skin came onto our hands."

The horrific images have continued to haunt him. "I took medicines and tried sleeping at night. I feel relief that we were able to help, but mostly remorse.

IN FOCUS



Tourists taking part in river rafting activity in the Beas river

PTI

Putin blasts detrimental Western interference in Moscow-Delhi ties

VIJAY JOSHI
■ St Petersburg

Russian President Vladimir Putin on Thursday hailed Moscow's strategic partnership with New Delhi and asserted that Western attempts to force India into scaling back its cooperation with Russia are futile and damaging to global stability.

In an interaction with heads of leading global news agencies including PTI, Putin lauded India's economic growth and its independent foreign policy and said Russia is determined to expand its economic engagement with the country.

"India is among the world's major economies and is currently demonstrating an impressive rate of economic growth," Putin remarked, expressing confidence that bilateral trade between the two nations is on track to hit a USD 100 billion milestone in the coming years.

"India is one of the leading economies of the world that has showed the highest rate of economic growth. This is not something that comes out of the blue. This is result of the hardwork that the government of India has been doing under the leadership of



Prime Minister Narendra Modi," Putin said.

The Russian President emphasised that New Delhi will continue to prioritise its own national interests, adding that India's diplomatic engagement with the United States does not hinder or undermine its time-tested relationship with Russia.

"We are glad that India is developing its relations with all countries it thinks important for its national interests," Putin said when asked whether India's deep alignment with Washington creates structural friction for Russia.

At the same time the Russian president added that there have been Western attempts to put pressure on when it comes to cooperation with Russia. (PTI)

Delhi LG orders crackdown on unauthorised construction

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday chaired a high-level review of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi and directed officials to come up with a comprehensive plan to target, halt, and dismantle unauthorised constructions across the capital. The directives were issued a day after a hotel fire in Malviya Nagar killed 21 people and exposed how extensively buildings in the city have been expanded and modified without permission or inspection.

The LG directed MCD to implement a time-bound strategy to tackle unauthorised constructions decisively. "He asked for a regulatory framework that ensures strict enforcement of building bylaws, penalising illegal constructions and expansions, and fixes absolute institutional accountability across all municipal zones," an official said. Local engineers, technical staff, and municipal oversight officers will be directly held account-



LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu chairs a high-level MCD review on Thursday

PIONEER PHOTO

able for any undetected illegal modifications or unauthorised construction within their jurisdictions, the official added.

Sandhu also directed the corporation to identify, process, and act against illegal residential and commercial vertical expansions that violate approved building blueprints or standard safety codes. A high-intensity drive has been mandated for complete detection and sealing or demolition of all ongoing

and existing unauthorised constructions within a strict time-frame. The LG's directions are directly linked to the Malviya Nagar fire of Wednesday, in which 21 people died at a bed-and-breakfast facility that had been operating 25 rooms against a permitted six, with additional floors built without informing authorities and without any valid fire safety clearance.

The MCD meeting also addressed other infrastructure issues, includ-

ing desilting of stormwater drains ahead of the monsoon, road and pavement repairs for dust mitigation, and intensified garbage clearance to strengthen sanitation.

On the enforcement front, the MCD has moved quickly. The corporation will write to the Tourism Department seeking cancellation of licences for 12 bed-and-breakfast facilities identified as operating in violation of norms in and around the Hauz Rani locality where the fire occurred. Once the licences are revoked, the properties will be sealed.

"We have identified 12 such buildings operating in violation of norms. Since they have got licences under the bed-and-breakfast scheme, first we will get those licences cancelled. Once the licences are revoked, we will be able to seal them," a senior MCD official told. The official did not confirm whether the 12 properties include those linked to the owner of Flourish Stay. The owner, Lavkesh Bajaj, was arrested in connection

with the fire on Wednesday evening. Locals said he allegedly operated two other properties in the area under the names Flourish Inn and Green Residency.

In South Delhi's Saket area, where a multi-storey building collapsed on May 30, killing six people, the MCD has identified 32 additional properties in violation of norms. Fresh notices to vacate will be issued to these properties by Friday. Properties will be sealed after the 72-hour notice period. Previously, eight notices had been issued.

Flourish Stay was located in Hauz Rani village within the Lal Dora area. The building was rebuilt around 2012 to 2013 and did not have a sanctioned building plan or approved layout.

The locality has grown into a dense cluster of guest houses and B&B establishments over the years because of its proximity to a major private hospital that draws patients from across India and abroad. The cause of the fire remains under investigation.

DMK to skip INDIA bloc strategy meet next week

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi/Chennai

The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam (DMK) on Thursday indicated that it will not be attending the INDIA bloc meeting scheduled to be held on Monday. Led by the Congress, 15 Opposition parties are expected to meet on June 8 at the Constitution Club in New Delhi to discuss their joint strategy to take on the BJP-led government and reinforce opposition unity.

TMC supremo and former West Bengal CMMamata Banerjee, party general secretary Abhishek Banerjee, Shiv Sena (UBT) chief Uddhav Thackeray, Samajwadi Party

president Akhilesh Yadav, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge are among those likely to attend the meeting, as per the sources.

The development follows a dramatic shift in Tamil Nadu's political landscape after the just concluded Assembly elections, where the Congress parted ways with the DMK, to back a Government led by actor-politician C Joseph Vijay and his party, Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK). The realignment brought an end to years of Congress-DMK collaboration and led to an exchange of barbs between the two parties.



DMK chief MK Stalin, Udhayanidhi Stalin, Kanimozhi Karunanidhi, paying tribute to former Tamil Nadu CM M Karunanidhi on his birth anniversary on Wednesday

PTI

On Thursday, DMK MPs were also given the approval by the Lok Sabha secretariat to sit separate from Congress MPs in the lower house.

Earlier, DMK leader Kanimozhi Karunanidhi had written to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla seeking permission to change the seating

arrangement in view of the emerging political circumstances.

Congress had contested the assembly polls as part of the pre-poll alliance with the DMK. This has led to acrimony between the two parties with senior DMK leaders calling this action of the Congress "backstabbing" and "betrayal". Congress, however, justified its action, saying the DMK had also contested the 2014 election alone.

Arvind Kejriwal led Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) has already distanced itself from the INDIA bloc and is not likely to attend the meeting, scheduled to take place at the Constitution Club.

UP tourism should drive a cultural renaissance: CM Yogi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Lucknow

Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday said tourism development in the State should not be restricted to building infrastructure alone, it must result in cultural renaissance, employment generation, local economic growth and global recognition.

Reviewing the functioning of the Tourism Department at a meeting



with officials, the chief minister said Uttar Pradesh is not only a centre of faith but also a representative of India's cultural conscious-

ness, spiritual traditions and knowledge heritage.

"Tourism development in the state should be linked with cultural renaissance, employment generation, local economic growth and global recognition, rather than being confined to infrastructure creation alone," he was quoted as saying in a statement.

Tourism has a crucial role in accelerating the state's cultural economy and can provide wider opportunities to local

products, handicrafts, traditional arts, cuisine and the service sector, he added.

Reviewing the Gyan Bharatam Mission, which is aimed at preserving India's knowledge traditions, Adityanath said ancient manuscripts are invaluable treasures reflecting the country's civilisation, philosophy, science and cultural consciousness. Their preservation and digitisation are not merely archival exercises but a means of

connecting future generations with their roots.

Officials informed the meeting that more than 1.37 million manuscripts have so far been surveyed, digitised and preserved under the initiative. During a review of proposed amendments to the Tourism Policy-2022, the chief minister said Uttar Pradesh should be developed as a leading destination for investment, innovation and experience-based tourism.

BJP RS picks hint at Cabinet reset

Nominations for elections for 27 Rajya Sabha seats are currently underway till June 8. The 10 States where these biennial elections are due by June 18 are Andhra Pradesh (4 seats), Gujarat (4 seats), Karnataka (4 seats), Madhya Pradesh (3 seats), Rajasthan (3 seats), Jharkhand (2 seats), Arunachal Pradesh (1 seat), Manipur (1 seat), Meghalaya (1 seat), Mizoram (1 seat). Additionally, bye-elections are being held for one seat each in Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, and Odisha.

BJP's central election committee has named Debashish Samantaray as its candidate for the Rajya Sabha poll from Odisha. Samantaray had recently joined the BJP, quitting the BJD. He was a Rajya Sabha MP from Odisha before he quit the party and resigned from the Upper House.

Sources said that party leadership, which had met to discuss the names for RS berths recently, gave more power to the States to figure out the suitable candidates to field in the biennial elections. PM Modi and his entire cabinet were also present in the meeting.

According to the list released by the party, Rajubhai Shukla, Mukeshbhai Rathwa, Mansingh Parmar, and Jitendra Meghijibhai Kanzariya will contest as BJP candidates from Gujarat, while Rajneesh Agrawal will join the fray from Madhya Pradesh. The party has fielded A Sharda Devi as its candidate from Manipur and Tai Tagak from Arunachal Pradesh, according to the list released by the party's national general secretary Arun Singh. Party sources said that Sharda Devi was the sole choice from a total of 18 applications, including Manipur Chief Minister N Biren Singh, received at the State unit. The term for the current Rajya Sabha member from the state, Leishemba Sanajaoba, also ends on June 21.

Delhi scraps B&B policy, a day after devastating...

Police investigations revealed that what was licensed as a six-room bed-and-breakfast (B&B) was in Malviya Nagar, in reality, operating as a 26-room hotel. While the restaurant operating on the first floor had permission only to run a tea-and-snack outlet. The structure never received a sanctioned building plan from the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and lacked a mandatory fire safety No-Objection Certificate (NOC).

The B&B scheme, introduced under the Incredible India Bed and Breakfast Act, 2007, was designed to promote affordable accommodation

in residential neighbourhoods while ensuring basic safety and quality standards. The rules limit establishments to a maximum of six double-bed rooms that require adequate ventilation, lighting, water supply, power arrangements and parking facilities. The owner must also reside on the premises, and the property is not meant to function as a commercial hotel.

According to experts, the policy, officially known as National Capital Territory of Delhi (Incredible India) Bed and Breakfast Establishment (Registration and Regulation) Act, 2007— which started during the Commonwealth Games held in Delhi in 2010 — has serious loopholes regarding safety norms.

"When the B&B scheme was started in Delhi during the Commonwealth Games, there was a provision that in the residential building, the owner had to live in the building, which was later removed from the scheme. In this accident, we see that the owner was not living with them," Rajesh Pawar, former Delhi chief fire officer, said. Panwar said in the policy, there was no provision for fire extinguishers or fire safety. "There was only one point that heat and smoke detectors should be desirable rather than mandatory, making installation entirely at the owner's discretion. I think heat and smoke detectors should be mandatory in the policy.

Urban planning expert Jagdish Mamgain said the city has witnessed a series of fatal incidents in recent months, raising concerns about enforcement and regulatory oversight.

"In the last one to one-and-a-half years, Delhi has witnessed several deaths due to fire incidents and building collapses. The latest fire tragedy and the building collapse in Saidulajab point to a larger systemic issue that needs attention," he said.

Mamgain, a former chairman of the works committee of the erstwhile unified Municipal Corporation of Delhi, said the frequent incidents suggest gaps in monitoring and enforcement.

The tourism department has released a draft policy proposing several changes to the existing framework. It introduced two categories — Gold and Silver — with classification based on factors such as room size, furnishings, sanitation standards, guest amenities and safety arrangements. The draft policy proposes allowing residential properties to operate small-scale guest accommodation facilities with a minimum of one room and a maximum of eight rooms or 16 beds.

The tourism department has invited objections and suggestions from stakeholders and the public within 30 days of May 26 through email and post for improving the draft policy in line with the requirements of the industry, the visi-

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tors and the convenience of users. The draft policy puts emphasis on guest safety, particularly of women travellers. All registered B&B units will be required to maintain verified guest records, upload guest details on the tourism department portal and comply with police verification norms. Operators will also have to install fire extinguishers, smoke or heat detectors, first aid kits and proper locking systems. CCTV coverage has also been proposed for entrance and common areas in higher-category units.

According to Mishra, the draft further proposes strict monitoring and compliance provisions. Authorities will be empowered to inspect premises without prior notice and issue rectification notices if deficiencies are found. Continued violations may lead to suspension, cancellation or blacklisting of registrations. A registration may also be cancelled in cases involving misrepresentation, criminal activities, serious hygiene or safety violations, misuse of premises or repeated non-compliance with operational guidelines.

DU assistant professor found murdered in east...

The body has been shifted to Lal Bahadur Shastri Hospital for post-mortem. The exact cause of death will be ascertained after receiving the autopsy report, officials said.

A case has been registered under Section 103(1) (murder) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita at New Ashok Nagar police station.

Police said multiple teams have been formed to identify and apprehend the accused. Investigators are examining all possible angles, including the victim's recent movements, contacts and CCTV footage from the area.

Further investigation is underway, police added.

Dawood, betting, IPL: Lalit Modi makes fresh...

The betting groups pursued both money and power, escalating matters. The situation came to a head in London in 2012, after Modi left India, when a fixer called at 3:30 am and told him to go to a penthouse owned by 'Baba'.

The man demanded that Modi help the syndicate get an IPL team. When Modi raised the Dawood problem; in India, Baba said, "I'll fix it". He went to the terrace, took out a satellite phone, and called Dawood. Baba said, "Dawood bhai, Lalit bhai aaya hai. Baat karo".

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Modi declined to speak. According to his account, Dawood said, "You are his friend, forget everything, it is all over. Without doubt."

Modi alleges that the pressure increased and that the Mumbai Police provided him with Z-category security after reported threats. Modi asserted there were three attempts on his life, allegedly ordered by Dawood, in Bombay, Johannesburg, and near the Croatian border in Montenegro.

He also claimed his son was kidnapped in London on Sloane Street by individuals connected to "Baba." "They went after me," Modi said. According to Modi, the standoff against the syndicates ended only after he promised to retire from cricket shortly after the 2012 London meeting. Chhota Shakeel, Dawood's aide, later publicly claimed their differences were resolved. Modi said this was central to his decision to leave cricket completely by 2012. He added that safety fears, constant media scrutiny, and government pressure left him no choice.

Modi has lived in London since 2010. He rejects the "fugitive" label and insists he faces no active cases that forced his exit. These are not entirely new allegations, but Modi links his final severance to threats.

In 2015, Mumbai Police backed claims that Dawood and Chhota Shakeel targeted Modi and his family over unpaid extortion during a trip to Thailand after 2010. In his 2026 interview, Modi gave his most detailed account yet of the 2012 London meeting and the earlier attempt to take over an IPL team. So far, no one has independently confirmed the 2012 incident.

The BCCI and Indian authorities have not commented on these claims. These stories come as the IPL, now worth over \$10 billion, faces new questions about its management. In this context, Lalit Modi's story raises old questions about corruption in cricket. The illegal betting market, worth \$40 billion a year, has grown with ball-by-ball betting since the IPL started in 2008. Moreover, smaller leagues remain at risk, and D-Company is reportedly still active in Karachi.

Bihar hospital fire kills five

The bodies have been handed over to family members after post-mortem examination, officials said. All patients admitted have been accounted for, they said.

Earlier in the day, Muzaffarpur District Magistrate Subrat Kumar Sen had said around 13 to 15 patients were being treated in the ICU, who were later shifted to other hospitals. Prima

Four injured in LPG cylinder blast at food stall in Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Four people sustained burn injuries after an LPG cylinder allegedly burst at a small food stall operating from a house in central Delhi's Nabi Karim area on Thursday morning, police and fire officials said. The incident was reported at around 9.29 am from a house in Amarpur, after which teams from the Delhi Police and the Delhi Fire Services (DFS) rushed to the spot.

According to preliminary investigations, the blast occurred in a small room on the ground floor of the house that Sarita (35) was using to prepare and sell tea and simple meals, including dal-rice. Police said Sarita had asked Krishan (37) to replace an LPG cylinder. A fire reportedly broke out while the regulator was being opened. Fire officials, however, said the incident involved an LPG cylinder burst inside the food stall resulting in burn injuries to four people. All the injured were shifted to Ram Manohar Lohia Hospital by PCR and CATS ambulances before fire tenders reached the spot.

The injured were identified as Sarita, Ajay (19), Zakir (35), and Krishan.

facie, the fire appears to have resulted from a short circuit, he said, adding that the exact cause of the blaze can be ascertained after a detailed investigation.

Singh said the DM has constituted a five-member team to probe into the incident. Chief Minister Samrat Choudhary described the incident as "extremely tragic" and expressed condolences to the bereaved families. BJP national president Nitin Nabin, too, expressed grief over the loss of lives in the blaze.

Former chief minister Nitish Kumar said the incident was heart-wrenching and expressed condolences to the bereaved families.

Eight pyres, one broken family

"He called me about 10 minutes before the incident got worse. He was frantically saying, 'I am trapped in the basement. Please send the fire brigade quickly and get me out of here,'" Garg says, his voice trembling.

"All eight are gone. My entire family has been destroyed. They came here hoping that my cousin's father would recover from his illness. Instead, we are taking back the bodies of our loved ones," he says.

Relatives say the family booked rooms at the hotel because of its proximity to the hospital where Vivek's ailing father, Radhe Shyam Agarwal, was undergoing treatment.

As post-mortem formalities were being conducted throughout the day, the bodies of the deceased family members were handed over to relatives and taken to their residence in Gurugram, where the last rites are expected to be performed in the evening.

"There are no words to describe this loss. In a few hours, everything changed," a grieving family member said.

Standing outside the mortuary, relatives questioned the safety arrangements at the hotel, alleging that the building's design left guests with little chance of escaping.

"The hotel is located in a highly congested area. Going in and out is a hassle. There was only one exit point and a single staircase. Everything was covered with glass, and even the windows had iron grills," Garg alleged.

Prem Bansal, Tarjini Agarwal's father, said five members of his family and three other relatives were caught in the fire. "Out of the eight people involved, five died from my side of the family," he said. The tragedy has left surviving relatives struggling to comprehend the scale of the loss.

India, Venezuela to build energy ties

ASHOKE RAJ ■ New Delhi

India and Venezuela on Thursday pledged to establish a long-term energy partnership, leveraging their complementary strengths, as Prime Minister Narendra Modi held extensive talks with Venezuelan Acting President Delcy Rodriguez on strengthening bilateral economic cooperation.

The discussions focused on expanding collaboration across key sectors, including energy, critical minerals, pharmaceuticals, agriculture, automobiles, mining, and investment. Rodriguez arrived in India on Wednesday for a five-day visit aimed at deepening strategic and economic ties between the two countries.

The visit comes at a time when India is seeking to diversify its crude oil imports amid supply disruptions linked to the ongoing crisis in West Asia. Venezuela has emerged as a key energy supplier, with India's imports of Venezuelan crude gaining momentum since April. The South American nation is now India's third-largest source of crude oil.

Addressing a media briefing after the talks, Ministry of External Affairs Secretary (East) Rudrendra Tandon said Venezuela views India as a "preferred energy partner" because of the size of its economy and its

long-term demand for energy. "The discussions focused on forging an energy partnership. Venezuela sees India as a stable consumer for many years to come. There is a perfect complementarity between the two countries in the energy sector, covering both upstream and downstream activities," Tandon said.

Prime Minister Modi conveyed India's interest in expanding energy cooperation across the entire value chain, including exploration, production, refining, and related infrastructure. The Indian side also raised the issue of more than USD 500 million in pending dividends owed to ONGC Videsh Limited (OVL) from its operations in Venezuela. Tandon noted that Venezuelan authorities were "very sensitive" to the matter and acknowledged India's concerns.

Beyond energy, the two leaders explored opportunities to broaden economic engagement. Tandon highlighted Venezuela's vast natural resource base, which includes critical minerals, gold, diamonds, and other valuable resources.

"Mining cooperation featured prominently in the discussions. There was also interest in assessing Venezuela's resource potential and exploring possibilities for collaboration in this sector," he said. While



Prime Minister Narendra Modi during a bilateral meeting with Venezuela's Acting President Delcy Rodriguez at the Hyderabad House in New Delhi

declining to comment directly on Venezuela's political transition following the detention of former President Nicolas Maduro by US forces in January, Tandon emphasised India's commitment to maintaining strong relations with Caracas.

"We are working with a government that is friendly and keen to strengthen partnership with India. Venezuela has traditionally been a close friend of India, both bilaterally and at international forums," he said. The leaders also exchanged views on regional and global developments, including cooperation within BRICS. According to Tandon,

Venezuela's delegation praised India's leadership during its chairmanship of the grouping.

MEA spokesperson Randhir Jaiswal said the two sides reviewed the entire spectrum of bilateral relations and identified new opportunities for cooperation in trade, investment, healthcare, automobiles, and technology.

Rodriguez assumed office as acting president following Maduro's detention earlier this year. Her delegation includes ministers responsible for foreign affairs, economy and finance, science and technology, communication and informa-

tion, and transportation. During the visit, the Venezuelan delegation is scheduled to tour facilities linked to India's energy, pharmaceutical, and automobile industries. Officials said Rodriguez is expected to visit Reliance Industries' world-renowned refinery complex in Jamnagar, Gujarat.

"The Venezuelan leader will witness the sophistication and technological advancement India has achieved in the energy sector," Tandon said.

India and Venezuela share longstanding and cordial relations. Bilateral ties received a major boost during former Venezuelan President Hugo Chavez's state visit to India in 2005. Energy cooperation remains the cornerstone of the relationship.

ONGC Videsh currently operates in Venezuela through a joint venture with Corporacion Venezolana del Petroleo (CVP). The venture, Petrolera Indovenezolana SA, is engaged in oil exploration and production in the San Cristobal field, where OVL holds a 40 per cent stake.

With both nations seeking to deepen engagement in energy security and economic cooperation, the Modi-Rodriguez talks are expected to lay the groundwork for a more comprehensive strategic partnership in the years ahead.

Nation Focus



ANDHRA PRADESH CABINET GIVES NOD TO 34 PROPOSALS

The Andhra Pradesh Cabinet on Thursday approved 34 proposals, such as a new aviation policy, implementation of an organ transplantation law, revised funding for the Polavaram Left Main Canal project, and development of the proposed Amaravati Eye tourism initiative.

It also cleared several land allotments for renewable energy and industrial ventures. The decisions were taken at the 50th Cabinet meeting, chaired by Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu at the State Secretariat.

"The Cabinet approved 34 proposals covering multiple sectors, including irrigation, urban development, industries, healthcare, renewable energy, and rural development," said Information and Public Relations Minister K Parthasarathi at a press conference.

The Cabinet approved administrative sanction of ₹547 crore for external development works at the High Court complex in Amaravati, including parking facilities. (PTI)



OM BIRLS INAUGURATES PSK IN BUNDI DISTRICT

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Thursday inaugurated a Passport Seva Kendra (PSK) at the Head Post Office in Bundi district. Established by the Ministry of External Affairs, the PSK is expected to provide relief to the locals, who until now had to travel to Kota or Jaipur for passport-related services.

Speaking on the occasion, Birla said that until now, Bundi residents had to visit Jaipur for passport-related work, often facing long queues and, in some cases, extended stays of one or two days. (PTI)

India, UK to build new partnership: Jaishankar

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

India and the UK are well-positioned to construct a new future-oriented and mutually beneficial partnership on the back of their newly firmed-up comprehensive trade deal and the defence industrial roadmap, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Thursday.

He made the remarks during a meeting with visiting British Foreign Secretary Yvette Cooper. Highlighting 'remarkable

addresses many concerns about creating resilient supply chains and addressing concerns in areas of trade, energy, food and economic security.

"Our relationship has moved from being a historical and perhaps cultural connection to being a forward-looking highway of shared economic ambitions and high technology," he said.

The external affairs minister also made a mention of India-UK Vision 2035 and its five pillars such as growth, technology and



developments' in the bilateral ties in recent months, the external affairs minister pointed to Prime Minister Narendra Modi's visit to the UK last July, followed by UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer's trip to India in October.

Jaishankar highlighted the finalisation of the India-UK Comprehensive Economic and Trade Agreement (CETA), the adoption of comprehensive strategic partnership and the defence industrial roadmap as major achievements. "We are today well positioned to build a new future-oriented and mutually beneficial partnership," he said.

Jaishankar said CETA

innovation, defence and security, climate and clean energy, and education. He also referred to University of Liverpool's decision to open a campus in India.

In his remarks, Cooper, said the India-UK partnership has gone from "strength to strength" in recent years and cited CETA as one of the key pillars of economic growth. Crucially our commitment to economic security reflected in work on critical minerals, she said.

The India-UK Critical Minerals Global Supply Chain Observatory (GSCO) was formally launched on Thursday. Minister of Coal and Mines by G Kishan Reddy and Foreign Secretary Cooper.

Environment Ministry reconstitutes Nagaland regulatory bodies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Environment Ministry has reconstituted Nagaland's key regulatory bodies that evaluate and grant Environment Clearances (ECs) to projects at the State level.

These bodies are the State Environment Impact Assessment Authority (SEIAA) and the State Expert Appraisal Committee (SEAC). While the SEIAA grants ECs, the SEAC advises it in appraising the project.

"The Chairman and Member of the Authority and the Committee, shall hold office for a period of three years from the date of



publication of this notification in the Official Gazette," said the ministry's notification, issued on Thursday.

While the State's SEIAA comprises a chairman, a member, and a member secretary, the SEAC consists of a

World lacks solution for balanced progress: RSS chief Bhagwat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat on Thursday said the world does not possess a guiding principle that can ensure progress across multiple dimensions of human life simultaneously, and global systems remain confused over balancing individual welfare, societal interests and environmental protection.

Addressing the concluding event of a volunteer training camp of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh in Nagpur, Bhagwat said the world understands the development of the human body, mind and intellect separately, but has failed to evolve a framework that advances all three together.

"The world knows human body's development, as well as mind and intelligence. But the world does not know how to



RSS Chief Mohan Bhagwat with Aditya Birla Group Chairman Kumar Mangalam Birla during the closing ceremony of RSS 'Karyakarta Vikas Varg-II' at Reshimbagh in Nagpur, Maharashtra on Thursday

achieve progress on all the three fronts," he said.

Referring to contemporary global conflicts, Bhagwat said their effects are felt even by countries not directly involved. "War is (going on) between Iran and the US, but oil prices are increasing here in India," he said, adding that while people often focus on challenges and uncertainties,

they should also recognise the opportunities available in such difficult situations.

He said the world remains trapped in dilemmas involving individual rights and environmental conservation. "To give a person individual rights, society's interest is compromised. If society needs to be given powers, individual person's rights are suppressed," Bhagwat said.

Constitution expert Subhash Kashyap passes away

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

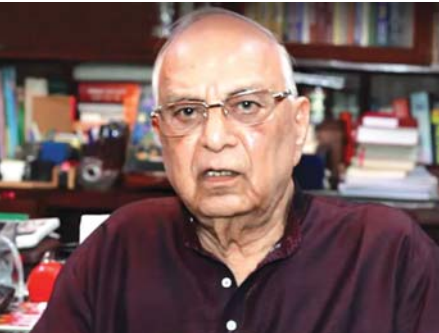
Former Lok Sabha Secretary General and constitutional expert Subhash C Kashyap passed away on Thursday after prolonged illness. He was 97. Kashyap's end came at around 10 am at his Sainik Farm residence, officials of the Lok Sabha Secretariat said.

He was suffering from age-related issues and died of cardio-pulmonary arrest, they said. Kashyap was part of the high-level committee headed by former president Ram Nath Kovind to prepare a legal framework on simultaneous elections.

President Droupadi Murmu on Thursday said the demise of renowned Constitution expert Subhash C Kashyap is extremely sad and offered condolences to his family.

Author of over 100 books, he served as the secretary general of Lok Sabha from 1983 to 1990. He served Parliament for over 37 years from the time of Jawaharlal Nehru's first Lok Sabha to the 9th Lok Sabha.

Born in 1929 in a family of freedom fighters at Chadpur in Bijinor in the then United Provinces (now Uttar Pradesh), he actively participated in the national struggle for Independence as a teenager, leading local student movements first in Bijinor and later Meerut. He received his higher education and professional training at Allahabad, New Delhi, Washington DC, London and Geneva. Kashyap began his professional career as



a journalist and as assistant professor at the University of Allahabad and undertook advocate's training at the Allahabad High Court before joining Parliament.

Recipient of many honours, he was awarded the Padma Bhushan.

After voluntary retirement from Parliament, he served as honorary constitutional advisor to the Government of India on Panchayati Raj Institutions laws, as a member and chairman of the drafting committee of the National Commission to Review the Working of the Constitution during the Atal Bihari Vajpayee Government and recently served as a member on the committee on 'One Nation, One Election' chaired by former president Ram Nath Kovind.

Kashyap is survived by his wife, two sons and a daughter.

Rahul working against India's stability: BJP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The BJP on Thursday hit back at Congress leader Rahul Gandhi over his claim that Prime Minister Narendra Modi will no longer remain in office in a year's time, accusing him of spreading propaganda to create "instability" in the country. Calling Gandhi a "certified anarchist", the ruling party also noted that the only Emergency imposed in the country was by former prime minister Indira Gandhi.

Gandhi, Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha, claimed on Wednesday that Modi will not be the prime minister in a year's time as the "system that he once controlled is now shaken and collapsing internally". He further alleged that the Modi Government may try to suppress the public pressure and impose something like an Emergency.



BJP IT department head Amit Malviya

Advise Congress at the Indira Bhawan here, Gandhi on Wednesday warned that while an "economic tsunami" is coming, the system is also revolting due to public pressure. Reacting sharply to the remarks, BJP IT department head Amit Malviya said that despite having "access" to information from various institutions and officials, his party continues to lose elections and shrink politically.

"Every few months, he unveils a new conspiracy theory. First, democracy was

over. Then institutions were captured. Then election rigging. Now we are told that an Emergency is coming and an economic tsunami is around the corner.

"The country has heard these predictions before. The problem is that none of them ever come true," Malviya said in a post on social media.

Referring to Gandhi's remarks that India is heading towards an "economic tsunami", Malviya said it is a classic case of "fear-mongering".

UPSC implements face authentication in 2026 exams

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Union Public Service Commission (UPSC) successfully implemented face authentication in the 2026 Civil Services preliminary examination, an official statement issued on Thursday said.

The face-authentication protocol ensures that the candidate whose photo was uploaded at the time of filling the application form matches when they appear with the admit card to write the exam, it said.

The system enabled live, real-time authentication of candidates at examination venues through mobile-phone-based verification by invigilators, ensuring seamless identification and eliminating the possibility of impersonation and malpractice, said the statement issued by the UPSC.

UPSC conducted a real-time face-authentication exercise across all 2,072



examination venues nationwide during this year's Civil Services (Preliminary) Examinations 2026, held on May 24, it said.

Out of a total of 8,19,732 candidates who had applied for the examination, nearly 5.49 lakh candidates (around 67 per cent) appeared for it, as per the provisional data.

The face authentication application has been developed and implemented by UPSC with technical support from the National e-Governance Division (NeGD)

of the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY).

UPSC has developed a business process which requires each candidate to undergo face authentication before they are allowed entry to the examination hall, the statement said.

UPSC has also devised a detailed Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) as part of this process, which has been shared with all states, districts and venues where the examination is proposed.

"Multiple rounds of training were imparted to the invigilators. The beauty of the solution lies in the fact that it does not require any expensive hardware. It works on any Android smartphone, and invigilators used their own mobile phones for the purpose, thereby reducing hardware costs and easing the logistical burden," it said.

Another significant feature of the application is its speed. The time required for a typical face authentication of a candidate is only about 6-8 seconds, which ensured smooth entry and prevented queuing at examination centres, it said.

The application's scalability was such that it was used by more than 7,000 invigilators simultaneously, and during the peak entry period, the application processed approximately 12,000 authentications per minute, the statement said.

UPSC Chairman Ajay Kumar said this is a new step

taken to ensure impersonation-free exams. The technology is fully developed in-house with the help of NeGD, he said.

"However, the challenge also lay in deploying the solution at scale, leveraging the existing invigilation workforce for face authentication, training them, and accomplishing all this within a short span of time. UPSC, NeGD and MeitY teams have done a great job in developing and implementing this solution successfully on such a large scale with nearly 5.5 lakhs candidates across 2000-plus venues," Kumar said.

The successful implementation of real-time face authentication is a significant step towards strengthening the integrity of the civil services examination process and reflects the Commission's continued commitment to transparency, fairness, and technological innovation in public examinations, the statement added.

States Focus



SCINDIA PROPOSES 5-POINT TO TRANSFORM NESAC

Union Minister Jyotiraditya Scindia on Thursday proposed five strategic initiatives to transform the North Eastern Space Applications Centre (NESAC) into a key driver of scientific innovation, climate resilience and data-driven governance in the Northeast. Addressing the 13th meeting of the NESAC Society, Scindia said the initiatives would help position the centre as a transformative institution for regional development, disaster preparedness and technology-led policymaking across the eight northeastern states.

The five initiatives are high-resolution village resource mapping, continuous monitoring of wetlands, forests, rivers and landscapes, promotion of geospatial and space-technology startups in the region, development of an all-hazard disaster resilience digital twin platform called "NER-Shield", and the creation of a Northeast Green Wealth and Natural Capital Accounting framework.



NEELKANTH MISHRA APPOINTED WORLD BANK EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR

Economist Neelkanth Mishra was on Thursday appointed as Executive Director of the World Bank in the US for a tenure of three years. He will succeed incumbent Parameswaran Iyer, a 1981 batch retired Indian Administrative Service (IAS) officer of Uttar Pradesh cadre. Iyer was appointed to the post in February 2023. The Appointments Committee of the Cabinet (ACC) has approved Mishra's appointment as Executive Director, World Bank Headquarters, Washington DC, USA, for a tenure of three years from the date of assumption of charge of the post, a Personnel Ministry order said. Mishra is a part-time member of the Economic Advisory Council to the Prime Minister (EAC-PM), an independent body constituted to give advice on economic and related issues to the Central government, specifically to the prime minister.

J&K Statehood fight needs credibility, says MP Mehdi

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

Striking a discordant note, ruling party Member of Parliament from Srinagar, Syed Aga Ruhullah Mehdi, Thursday warned the party leadership that any fight for the restoration of Jammu and Kashmir's Statehood and constitutional guarantees must be based on "consistency and credibility", not "theatrics or optics".

The incongruent party MP made these remarks a day after the Chief Minister Omar Abdullah escorted the party legislators and MP's to Dachigam National Park to review the functioning of the Government and gather their feedback over the issue of granting Statehood to Jammu and Kashmir.

At the end of the seven-hour-long session, the National Conference announced that its legislature party, along with



Member of Parliament from Srinagar Syed Aga Ruhullah Mehdi

alliance partners, will stage a protest in New Delhi on the opening day of the forthcoming Monsoon Session of Parliament to press for the restoration of Jammu and Kashmir's Statehood and constitutional guarantees.

Reacting to the announcement, Ruhullah, who claimed he was not invited to attend the party meeting at Dachigam, said a serious movement required a roadmap and outreach

across Kashmir and Delhi. "Do not try to fool people by sitting somewhere for a day. Make a roadmap. Reach out to the whole of Kashmir. Create a movement," he said.

"The credibility of the political leadership was at stake as people were asking questions", he added.

"The condition is that there should be sustainability and consistency. If there is no consistency, then there will be theatrics," the MP said. He also

called for forcing the Prime Minister's Office (PMO) and creating momentum inside and outside Parliament.

Citing the example of Ladakh, MP Mehdi said Kashmir's political leadership should learn how to fight unitedly for rights.

"If everyone is sincere, all political parties should suspend their political identities and come together on a single platform. We should build a democratic and peaceful movement until the rights taken away in 2019 are restored," he said. The MP said he was willing to take the first step by resigning from Parliament if a common movement was formed.

"I will be the first one to resign from Parliament. Let representatives be chosen from a common platform rather than party platforms until our constitutional rights are restored," he said.

Former CBFC chief Pahlaj Nihalani dies at 76

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Pahlaj Nihalani, producer of films such as "Aankhen" and former chairperson of the Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), died on Thursday. He was 76.

Nihalani passed away at his residence in Bandra due to liver ailments. His last rites were performed at the Santacruz Hindu crematorium.

Actor Govinda, who got his big break with Nihalani's 1986 production "Ilzaam", visited the producer's residence to pay his last respects.

The actor also attended the last rites of the producer.

"Pahlaj Nihalani ji laid the foundation stone for so many of us. Several artists, including me, who rose from difficult and financially challenging circumstances, received his support and encouragement.

"There must be at least a dozen artists in the country whose careers were shaped by his guidance. Pahlaj ji had a rare ability to identify talent and help people rise from the ground to



Pahlaj Nihalani, the veteran producer and former chairperson of CBFC died on Thursday PTI

great heights. It was a gift bestowed upon him by God," Govinda told PTI.

Others who paid their last respects to the producer included filmmakers Farhan Akhtar, Zoya Akhtar, Anees Bazmee, David Dhawan and sons Rohit

and Varun, Boney Kapoor, Ramesh Sippy and Abhishek Kapoor.

Veteran actor and politician Shatrughan Sinha also attended Nihalani's funeral.

"He was one of our closest friends and a family friend. Our association with him goes back many years. He was a great filmmaker, a wonderful human being, a sincere friend, and a person with an outstanding personality. He also served as the chairman of the censor board. He gave us many blockbuster films. Above all, what stood out most was his humanity," he told PTI.

Nihalani started his career as a producer with the 1982 movie "Haathkadi". He is widely credited for giving actor Govinda his first big break with the 1986 movie "Ilzaam". He also introduced actor Chunky Panday with "Aag Hi Aag" in 1987.

His other producing credits included "Shola Aur Shabnam", "Aankhen", "Dil Tera Diwana", "Talaash" and "Rangeela Raja".

Tharoor hails UDF Govt's white paper on Kerala's finances

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ New Delhi

After Kerala's UDF Government tabled a white paper on the state's financial health in the Assembly on Thursday, Congress leader Shashi Tharoor lauded Chief Minister VD Satheesan for beginning his term with candour rather than complacency, stating that transparency about "where we stand" is the precondition for sound policy.

these numbers honestly. Kerala's achievements in literacy, health and human development remain the envy of India.

The challenge now is to ensure that our finances can sustain — and build upon — them, so that the next generation inherits opportunity, not merely a legacy to defend," the Congress leader said. Tharoor said part of this stress is not of Kerala's own making. Shrinking of the



Noting that the paper's findings are sobering, Tharoor said Kerala has overcome harder tests before, and with transparency, discipline and collective resolve, it will do so again.

Welcoming the new Government's decision to publish a candid status report on Kerala's fiscal health, the Thiruvananthapuram MP said, "Transparency about where we stand is the precondition for sound policy, and an honest baseline serves citizens far better than comfortable budgetary fictions. The findings are sobering," he said.

Tharoor noted that committed expenditure consuming nearly 77 per cent of the state's revenue, capital spending being among the lowest in India, and over ₹48,000 crore in inherited arrears point to deep structural stress, and not a passing difficulty.

"We must confront

divisible pool through cesses and surcharges, the end of Revenue Deficit Grants, and ever more conditional transfers have squeezed every state.

Cooperative federalism cannot be a one-way street, he added. "At the same time, we must address what lies within our control: off-budget structures whose liabilities now rest on the state, loss-making enterprises, and budgeting that strayed from realism. The CAG's findings deserve a serious, non-partisan response," Tharoor said.

He said the report rightly notes there's a limit to belt-tightening.

"The answer is growth: private and cooperative investment, power-sector reform, and making Kerala a hub for higher education, AI and new industry that keep our talented youth employed at home," the MP said.

Need inter-State, global cooperation on natural disasters: Odisha CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Puri

Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi on Thursday called for greater inter-state and global cooperation to address the growing challenges of climate change and natural disasters.

Majhi was addressing the inaugural session of the technical meeting of the BRICS Disaster Risk Reduction Working Group (DRRG) here, where he reiterated Odisha's commitment to disaster resilience, climate adaptation and sustainable development.

Eleven member countries of BRICS are participating in the three-day meeting hosted by the National Disaster Management Authority (NDMA), which got underway on Wednesday.

The chief minister described the gathering as a significant platform for advancing global disaster risk reduction efforts.

The meeting's theme — 'Building for Resilience, Innovation, Cooperation and



Odisha Chief Minister Mohan Charan Majhi in a group picture during the 2nd BRICS Technical Meeting DRR Group in Puri PTI

Sustainability' — reflects the urgent priorities of the international community in safeguarding lives, livelihoods and future generations through greater cooperation, he said.

"Disaster risk reduction is no longer a standalone sectoral concern, but a cornerstone of sustainable development, economic stability and human security," Majhi asserted.

Climate change, rapid urbanisation and environmental degradation are increasing both the frequency and intensity of disasters

across the world, demanding stronger preparedness and coordinated action, he said.

Highlighting the importance of the BRICS platform in fostering collaboration among emerging economies on critical issues such as disaster risk reduction, climate adaptation, resilient infrastructure and capacity building, Majhi urged participating nations and experts to move beyond discussions, and convert deliberations into concrete partnerships and actionable outcomes that benefit vulnerable populations across the world.

Sonowal discusses ₹19,209 cr investment plan with Suvendu to boost Bengal maritime sector

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Kolkata

Union Minister Sarbananda Sonowal on Thursday met West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari and discussed a proposed investment of ₹19,209 crore aimed at transforming the state into eastern India's maritime, logistics and shipbuilding hub by 2031.

The nearly one-and-a-half-hour meeting was the first formal engagement between the Union ministry of ports, shipping and waterways and the West Bengal Government since the BJP assumed power in the state in May.

According to a ministry statement, the proposed projects are expected to generate more than 62,500 direct and indirect employment opportunities while strengthening ports, inland waterways, shipbuilding, logistics and port-led industrialisation in the State.

The investment roadmap, planned under the Maritime



Union Minister of Ports Sarbananda Sonowal with West Bengal CM Suvendu Adhikari during a meeting at Nabanna PTI

Amrit Kaal Vision 2047, includes development of the Balagarh Multimodal Logistics Hub, expansion and mechanisation of Kolkata and Haldia docks, strengthening of inland waterways, creation of shipbuilding and ship repair facilities, cruise tourism infrastructure, riverfront redevelopment and port-led industrial clusters.

The meeting came a day after Adhikari held talks with Adani Ports & SEZ Ltd MD

Karan Adani, who is the son of Adani Group chairman Gautam Adani, at Nabanna and is seen as significant amid reduced engagement between the country's largest private port operator and the previous TMC Government in recent years.

During Thursday's meeting between Sonowal and Adhikari, both leaders discussed future development of ports, inland waterways, shipbuilding, logistics and connectivity projects in the state. "West Bengal is central to India's maritime future. Under the dynamic leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, with an investment pipeline of nearly ₹19,209 crore, we aim to transform Bengal's maritime hubs — Kolkata and Haldia — into the premier maritime gateway of eastern India while generating more than 62,500 employment opportunities," Sonowal said.

The Union Minister for Ports, Shipping and Waterways said the investment programme was designed to attract private capital, create large-scale employment and establish West Bengal as a preferred destination for maritime and logistics investments.

He said the proposed investments would strengthen logistics efficiency, reduce transportation costs, support exports and create an enabling ecosystem for industries dependent on maritime connectivity.

GUJARAT DY CM INAUGURATES 3-DAY GLOBAL RECYCLING EXPO & SUMMIT

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Gandhinagar

Gujarat Deputy Chief Minister Harsh Sanghavi on Thursday virtually inaugurated three-day 'GREENS 2026 — the Global Recycling Expo & Summit' here, which brings together stakeholders from across India's recycling and circular economy ecosystem.

The event will continue till June 6, an official release said. Sanghavi inaugurated the summit, jointly organised by SALT Alliances and the Gujarat Chamber of Commerce and Industry (GCCCI) at the Helipad Exhibition Centre in Gandhinagar, it said.

SALT Alliances' director Ketan Prajapati said India's growth could no longer rely on a linear model of consumption and disposal, adding that the circular economy is the future of manufacturing and economic growth.

Monsoon arrives in Kerala, marking start of rainy season

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

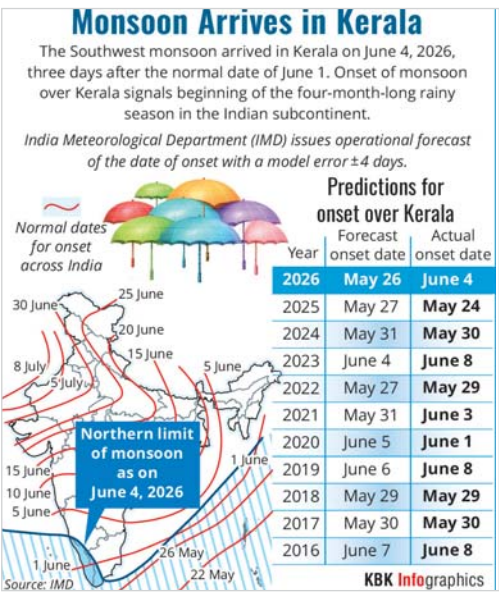
■ New Delhi

The southwest monsoon made its onset over Kerala on Thursday, marking the start of the country's four month rainy season (June-September), according to the India Meteorological Department (IMD). Typically, the monsoon arrives in Kerala around June 1, which marks the beginning of the Southwest monsoon season (June-September). The monsoon delivers nearly 70 per cent of India's annual rainfall and remains crucial for the farm sector, which supports millions of livelihoods.

"The southwest monsoon has further advanced into the remaining parts of southwest and southeast Arabian Sea, some parts of westcentral and eastcentral Arabian Sea, entire Lakshadweep islands, Kerala and Mahe, some parts of Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, remaining parts of Comorin area, southeast Bay of Bengal and some more parts of southwest, westcentral, eastcentral and northeast Bay of Bengal today the 4th June, 2026," the IMD said.

Previously, the weather department had predicted that the monsoon would begin over Kerala on May 26; however, the arrival was delayed.

The IMD issued an orange alert in Alappuzha, Kottayam and Ernakulam districts on Thursday



morning, warning of thunderstorms accompanied by heavy rain and surface wind speeds of up to 40 kmph.

Last week, the department revised its forecast for seasonal rainfall, indicating that it would be below normal. The IMD expects rainfall in India to be around 90 per cent of the long-period average (LPA) this year.

The LPA refers to the rainfall recorded in a specific region over a defined period, such as a month or season, averaged over a long duration, typically 30 to 50 years.

The long-period average (LPA) of seasonal rainfall over the country as a whole, based on data from 1971 to 2020, is 87 cm. If the monsoon season sees less than 90 pc of LPA rainfall, the IMD classifies it as 'deficient'. One reason behind the below-normal rainfall could be the emergence of El Nino conditions, which lead to less rain during the monsoon in the country.

Currently, neutral El Nino-Southern Oscillation conditions are transitioning towards El Nino conditions over the equatorial Pacific region. The India Meteorological Department said that El Nino conditions are likely to be weak in June, and moderate to strong in September. The kharif season, which begins in June, accounts for more than half of India's foodgrain output, making the performance of the monsoon a key factor influencing farm production and food inflation.

Kashmir IGP reviews Amarnath Yatra preparations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Srinagar

Kashmir IGP VK Birdi on Thursday reviewed the security and logistical arrangements being put in place for this year's Amarnath Yatra that begins next month.

Birdi emphasised the importance of coordinated efforts among all stakeholders to ensure timely completion of all arrangements for a safe, secure and hassle-free experience of pilgrims.

The annual pilgrimage to the holy cave shrine of Amarnath in south Kashmir will commence on July 3 and conclude after 57 days on August 28. Pilgrims between the ages of 13 and 70 can undertake the yatra.

"In preparation for the forthcoming Shri Amarnath Ji Yatra 2026, IGP Kashmir V K Birdi, accompanied by DIG



Central Kashmir Range Rajiv Pandey and SSP Ganderbal Sudhanshu Dhama visited the Baltal base camp to review the pace of security and logistical arrangements

being put in place for the smooth conduct of the yatra," a police spokesperson said here. During the visit, the officers inspected

various facilities established for Jammu and Kashmir Police and Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) personnel deployed for the yatra.

They assessed the preparedness of security infrastructure, accommodation, communication facilities, and other essential arrangements at the base camp, he said.

Karnataka CM promises free, fair Government

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Bengaluru

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar on Thursday said that his Government would set up a separate secretariat to address public grievances.

He also asked officials to prepare action plans for their respective departments within fifteen days. He directed them not to succumb to pressure and to work with integrity, conscience, and a positive approach.

A day after assuming office, the CM held a meeting with top bureaucrats and police officials in the State, during which he stressed providing a "free, fair, and corruption-free" Government.

"A separate secretariat will be established to address public grievances, and a minister will be appointed to listen to people coming to Bengaluru from across the State with complaints, demands, or issues, including those staging protests or agitations. There is a need for such a separate secretariat," Shivakumar told reporters after the meeting.

He added, "Every day, two or three groups come here to protest. Someone



Karnataka Chief Minister DK Shivakumar addressing a high-level review meeting with Additional Chief Secretaries, Principal Secretaries and senior police officers at Vidhana Soudha in Bengaluru

has to meet them and understand their problems. It is important to determine whether their demands are legal or illegal. Officials must meet them, hear the facts, and understand their issues. Therefore, a decision has been made to establish a separate secretariat."

Deputy Chief Minister G Parameshwara, Minister Ramalinga Reddy, Chief Secretary Shalini Rajneesh, Director General of Police M A Saleem, and other senior officials were present.

Stating that the new Government had begun its

work, Shivakumar said officials had been informed about the Government's priorities and direction.

"We told them what is expected of them, and they, in turn, told us what they expect from us," he said.

The CM said his Government would not tolerate influence based on caste or religion, and asked officials not to yield to pressure.

"Officials must respond transparently to the feelings and concerns of the people. They have been instructed to work with a positive approach," he said.

People of Uttarakhand sacrificed for Statehood: Rahul

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dehradun

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday said that people of Uttarakhand made immense sacrifices for its formation but are now being undermined by the Centre which is operating the State via remote control.

Gandhi, who cancelled his scheduled visit to Almora and Pauri Garhwal after his helicopter encountered severe weather conditions and he was forced to return to the Pantnagar airport, addressed two rallies virtually. Elections are slated to be held in the state next year.

Addressing the Almora rally over a phone call facilitated

by Congress general secretary and Uttarakhand in-charge Kumari Selja, the Leader of the Opposition in Lok Sabha alleged that the vision behind the creation of Uttarakhand was being undermined.

Though a major portion of his address over the phone was not clearly audible, Gandhi apologised to the gathering for his absence and targeted the ruling dispensation. He said the people of the state had envisioned a future where they retained self-determination rather than being governed by external forces.

"The Constitution states that India, that is Bharat, is a Union of States. You made immense sacrifices to form this State.



Regrettably, Uttarakhand is not being managed by its own people today; it is being operated via remote control from Delhi," he said.

He further alleged that outsiders are exploiting the

mantling" critical socio-economic protections. He highlighted four specific areas where he claimed these protections had eroded.

Firstly, he alleged that household savings and gold held by the public had been diminished.

Secondly, he stated that small and medium enterprises, particularly in the textile and food processing sectors, had been devastated by the flawed implementation of the Goods and Services Tax (GST).

Thirdly, the Congress leader criticised the current foreign policy alignment, claiming that India's energy security is now constrained by external geopolitical pressures.

Job portal launched in Ladakh

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Leh/Jammu

Lieutenant Governor Vinai Kumar Saxena on Thursday launched an integrated job portal in Ladakh, a dedicated online platform aimed at connecting job seekers and employers through a single-window digital interface and enhancing employment opportunities across the Union Territory.

The portal has been developed to provide a centralised employment ecosystem that brings together job opportunities from various sectors and simplifies the recruitment process for both candidates and employers, officials said.

Speaking at the launch, Saxena said employment was not merely about filling



vacancies but about creating opportunities, nurturing talent and enabling aspirations.

"The Integrated Job Portal Ladakh has been created to bridge the gap between job seekers and employers by providing a single-window digital platform where they can connect seamlessly.

Assam Cabinet expansion: 12 ministers to be sworn in today



TONY DAS ■ Guwahati

The Assam Cabinet will be expanded on Friday with the induction of 12 ministers, including three new faces, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma said.

The strength of the Assam Cabinet will now be 17, including the chief minister, as four other ministers had been sworn in earlier on May 12.

The maximum allowed strength of the Council of Ministers is 19. Thus, two positions would be left vacant for now.

The new faces are Ashwini Ray Sarkar, Nilima Devi and Sushanta Borgohain, and they all belong to the BJP.

AGP's Keshab Mahanta, also a minister in the previous NDA ministry, has also been included in the minis-

terial list. Biswajit Daimary, the Speaker of the previous Assembly, is also on the list of new ministers.

The remaining ones were all ministers in Sarma's first Cabinet, and they are BJP leaders.

They are Ashok Singhal, Ranaj Pegu, Bimal Borah, Jayant Mallabaruah, Kaushik Rai, Krishnendu Paul and Pijush Hazarika.

"I am pleased to announce that the following Hon'ble Members of the Assam Legislative Assembly will be sworn in as Cabinet Ministers in the Government of Assam on 5 June 2026 at 12:45 PM," the CM said in a social media post.

The ministers sworn in earlier are AGP's Atul Bora, BPP's Charan Boro and BJP's Ajanta Neog and Rameshwar Teli.

Centre signs NeVA pact with West Bengal Assembly

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Ministry of Parliamentary Affairs on Wednesday signed a tripartite pact with the West Bengal government and the state's assembly for implementation of the National eVidhan Application (NeVA) in the eastern State.

NeVA is a work-flow system deployed on NIC Cloud, MeghRaj which helps the chair of the House to conduct the proceedings of the House smoothly and to conduct legislative business in a paperless manner.

"Attended the signing ceremony of the Tripartite Memorandum of Understanding among the @mpa_india, Government of West Bengal & the West

tant for the health of the democracy that the Parliament and state assemblies function properly.

"I extend my best wishes to the new Government in West Bengal & appreciate its swift decision to adopt the @neva_mpa platform, making the West Bengal Legislative Assembly the 33rd Legislature in the country to join this transformative initiative.

Renowned for its rich democratic, intellectual & cultural legacy, West Bengal will further strengthen the national digital legislature ecosystem, enhancing efficiency, accessibility & transparency while enriching NeVA with its vibrant parliamentary traditions, Rijiju said.

The NeVA is a device-neutral and member-centric



Bengal Legislative Assembly for implementation of the National eVidhan Application (NeVA) at Parliament House, New Delhi," Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju said.

The event was also attended virtually by West Bengal Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari and Assembly Speaker Rathindra Bose, among others. Addressing the event, Rijiju said that it was very impor-

application created to equip them to handle diverse House business smartly by putting entire information regarding member contact details, rules of procedure, list of business, notices, bulletins, bills, starred/unstarred questions and answers, papers laid, committee reports etc. in their hand held devices/ tablets and equip all legislatures/ departments to handle it efficiently.



Indian Youth Congress President Uday Bhanu Chib and supporters stage a protest against the alleged irregularities and paper leak in competitive examinations in Guwahati on Thursday

Dalai Lama congratulates new Karnataka CM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Dharamshala

Tibetan spiritual leader, the Dalai Lama, on Thursday congratulated DK Shivakumar on his swearing in as the CM of Karnataka and said the state and its people have extended warmth and hospitality to the Tibetan community settled there.

"Karnataka is home to more than 30,000 Tibetans in exile, the largest concentration of the Tibetan diaspora in India," the leader said in a letter.

"We are deeply grateful to the state and its people for their enduring friendship and generous support. It is a source of great pride that our principal centres of learning, rooted in the Nalanda tradition of ancient Indian wisdom, have found their home in Karnataka," he added.

"I take this opportunity to convey our heartfelt appreciation to the State Government and people of



Karnataka for the warmth and hospitality they have extended to the Tibetan community settled there.

"I wish you every success in meeting the challenges that may lie ahead, and in honouring the hopes and aspirations of the people of Karnataka, particularly in making a real difference to the lives of its most vulnerable citizens," he said.

In a separate release, the office of the Tibetan spiritual leader said he will visit New Delhi on Friday to undergo medical treatment on his left knee.

Indian national killed, 13 injured in attack on Kuwait International Airport; MEA assures assistance

ASHOKE RAJ
■ New Delhi

A day after an Indian national was killed and 13 others injured in an attack on Kuwait International Airport, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) on Thursday said that the Indian mission in Kuwait is in constant touch with the affected families and local authorities. The mortal remains of the deceased are expected to arrive in India on June 5.

Addressing an inter-ministerial briefing on the evolving situation in West Asia, Aseem R Mahajan, Additional Secretary (Gulf) in the MEA, expressed condolences to the family of the victim and outlined the Government's response.

"Yesterday, in an attack on Kuwait International Airport, an Indian national unfortunately lost his life. We express our deepest condolences to the family of the deceased," Mahajan said.

He added that the Indian Embassy in Kuwait is coordinating closely with local



Aseem R Mahajan, Additional Secretary (Gulf)

authorities and providing all necessary support to the family. "His mortal remains are expected to arrive in India tomorrow. Thirteen Indian nationals have also been injured in the attack and are currently undergoing treatment at various hospitals in Kuwait. Our mission is extending all possible assistance to the injured and remains in close contact with local authorities," he said.

The attack occurred on Wednesday amid heightened regional tensions between the United States and Iran, raising

concerns over the security situation in the Gulf region. This marks the second fatality involving an Indian national in Kuwait in recent months. Earlier, an Indian citizen was killed in Iranian strikes on a power and water desalination plant in Kuwait on March 30.

Mahajan said the MEA is closely monitoring developments across the Gulf and the wider West Asia region. Indian diplomatic missions are actively engaging with the Indian community and maintaining regular contact with community associations, pro-

fessional groups, organisations, and Indian companies to address concerns and provide timely assistance.

Providing an update on the regional travel situation, Mahajan noted that Iran's airspace remains partially open. He reiterated the Government's advisory urging Indian nationals to avoid travel to Iran and encouraged those currently in the country to leave with assistance from the Indian Embassy.

"So far, our embassy in Tehran has facilitated the movement of 2,557 Indian nationals out of Iran through land border routes," he said.

He also informed that Israel's airspace has reopened, with limited flight operations resuming to destinations within the region. These services can be used by Indian nationals seeking onward travel to India. The MEA continues to monitor the situation closely and remains committed to ensuring the safety and welfare of Indian citizens in the region.

Arunachal emerging as Northeast's growth engine: Khandu

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Itanagar

Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu on Thursday said the State is witnessing unprecedented growth across sectors, asserting that it is no longer viewed as a remote frontier but is rapidly emerging as a major growth engine of the Northeast.

Addressing the 73rd Plenary Session of the North Eastern Council (NEC) in Shillong, chaired by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Khandu highlighted the transformation taking place in the frontier State, driven by massive investments in infrastructure, tourism, agriculture, entrepreneurship and hydropower.

moving faster than ever before," Khandu said in a post on X after attending the plenary session.

Emphasising the pace of development, he said the State is witnessing remarkable progress from roads to airports, tourism to startups, agriculture to hydropower, adding that these sectors are attracting unprecedented growth and investment.

"What was once seen as a frontier is today emerging as a growth engine of the Northeast," the chief minister said, underlining Arunachal Pradesh's growing role in the region's economic transformation. Khandu expressed confidence about the future prospects of both Arunachal Pradesh and the Northeast, stating that the region



Arunachal Pradesh Chief Minister Pema Khandu

stands at a defining moment in its development journey.

"The opportunities before Arunachal and the Northeast have never been greater," he said. Calling for an ambitious approach to development, Khandu urged stake-

holders to seize the moment and accelerate the pace of progress. "The time to think big, act boldly, and deliver results is now," he added.

The 73rd NEC Plenary Session brought together governors, chief ministers

and senior officials from all eight northeastern states to deliberate on regional development priorities and strengthen inter-State cooperation.

The meeting was also attended by Union Minister for Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER) Jyotiraditya Scindia, Minister of State for DoNER Sukanta Majumdar and other senior policymakers.

The plenary session assumes significance as it is discussing the North East Vision Plan 2047, a long-term roadmap aimed at transforming the region into a hub of economic growth, connectivity, innovation, sustainability and cultural prosperity by the centenary year of India's Independence, officials said.

Kuki apex body concerned over ongoing SIR exercise in Manipur

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Imphal

The apex body of the Kukis in Manipur on Thursday raised concerns over the ongoing SIR exercise in the State, claiming that nearly 59,000 internally displaced people of the community are unable to return home to participate in the process.

In a statement, Kuki Inpi Manipur (KIM) said, "The ongoing Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Manipur is unacceptable under the prevailing circumstances and raises serious concerns regarding fairness, inclusivity and administrative responsibility."

KIM said it had expected



that the Government would first put in place adequate and practical arrangements to address the situation of the approximately 59,000 Kuki-Zo internally displaced persons (IDPs), who continue to remain displaced and are unable to return to their homes to participate in this exercise.

"Proceeding with such a critical electoral and admin-

istrative exercise without ensuring the participation of a large and vulnerable section of the population undermines the very principles of democratic representation," it said.

The exclusion, whether direct or indirect, of these IDPs from the SIR process renders the exercise incomplete and unacceptable in its present form, it added.

Editor's
TAKE

Delhi inferno:
Punish the guilty

Another Delhi fire tragedy highlights the cost of negligence, where profit took precedence over safety and enforcement failed

What we learn from mishaps is that we do not learn anything from them. Moreover, the cost of human life does not matter when it comes to making profits. Delhi has seen several fire disasters - the Uphaar Cinema fire (1997), the Anaj Mandi factory fire (2019), the Mundka building fire (2022), the Alipur paint factory fire (2024), the recent Dwarka fire (2026), to name a few, and now the latest Malviya Nagar hotel fire that killed at least 21 people. Despite the recurrence of these incidents, the rules remain lax and enforcement even poorer.

The facts emerging from the ashes of Hauz Rani are damning. The hotel held a Bed & Breakfast licence for a maximum of six rooms. It was running 25. It had no valid Fire Safety No Objection Certificate - a legal requirement for every commercial hospitality establishment in India. There was a single exit from the building, and even that outer gate was reportedly locked. Most of the foreign victims were from Nigeria, Mozambique, Somalia, Liberia, Bangladesh and Afghanistan – families of patients undergoing treatment at the nearby Max Hospital. Who is responsible? The answer is not one person but an entire ecosystem of failure.

First and most directly, the hotel owner, who illegally expanded the premises fourfold, operated without mandatory fire clearances, sealed windows and blocked exits. The absconding owner must be arrested, tried and punished to the fullest extent of the law.

But the owner did not act in a vacuum. Budget hotels and B&Bs across Delhi routinely flout fire norms with near-total impunity. Inspectors who were meant to verify compliance either never visited or certified compliance they never checked. Municipal and licensing authorities who permitted a six-room operation to quietly balloon into a 25-room commercial complex over months or years are equally culpable. Complicity through inaction is still complicity. They too must face accountability. Why does Delhi burn every summer? The answers are structural. The city's older residential neighbourhoods - Malviya Nagar, Karol Bagh and Paharganj - are dense, with narrow lanes that delay fire engines and buildings with no separation between structures. As temperatures breach 45°C, electrical loads spike, air conditioners run continuously, and ageing wiring sparks under the strain. Illegal construction, mixed-use buildings with restaurants below and hotels above, and virtually no culture of fire drills or safety training make every summer a disaster waiting to happen. The way forward demands more than condolences. Delhi needs a time-bound, ward-by-ward fire-safety audit of every hotel, B&B, hostel and lodge, with the results made public. Licences must be physically verified, not rubber-stamped. Building plans must match reality on the ground. Fire exits, sprinklers and smoke alarms must be non-negotiable conditions of operation, not optional upgrades. Those who fail inspections must be shut down immediately, not fined and forgotten. Above all, this cannot be another tragedy that fades from the news cycle.

Modi's green diplomacy comes of age

The agreements forged during Prime Minister Modi's visit reflect a broader vision of positioning India as both a leading advocate and a key driver of a sustainable, resilient and rules-based international order



SHEHZAD POONAWALLA : **VIJETA RATTANI**

A defining feature of Prime Minister Narendra Modi's recent five-nation tour, which covered the United Arab Emirates, the Netherlands, Sweden, Norway and Italy, was the prominence accorded to green partnerships. Clean energy, green technology, shipping, the blue economy and climate resilience figured decisively in the agenda, highlighting how environmental and economic stakes have converged at a moment of global uncertainty. India's engagement abroad is no longer confined to conventional diplomacy; rather, it is strategically investing in partnerships and channels that secure long-term strategic interests, including energy security. In the wake of global turmoil, the resultant disruptions in supply-chain networks have exposed the vulnerabilities of fossil-fuel systems. The emphasis, therefore, is on convergence around clean energy, green technology and climate resilience, advancing self-reliance while shaping global environmental discourse and reinforcing a rules-based international order.

Bolstering green diplomacy

The Green Strategic Partnership with Norway elevates cooperation in clean energy, Arctic collaboration, defence technology, and other areas. With Sweden, the partnership focuses on green transition and resilient supply chains, while with the Netherlands, the engagement encompasses solar innovation, green hydrogen, storage and renewable investments, alongside maritime and sustainable agriculture. In the case of Italy, Prime Minister Modi and his counterpart, Prime Minister Meloni, agreed to strengthen the 2025-2027 Executive Programme for Scientific Cooperation, promoting joint research in renewable energy, quantum technologies, green hydrogen and the blue economy. Their joint tree-planting exercise underscored support for Prime Minister Modi's domestic green drive. Further, elevating the India-Nordic relationship to a Green Technology and Innovation Strategic Partnership further consolidates this vision. The tour, which secured nearly \$40 billion in investments, including from the UAE, is pivotal for its agenda, scope and timing.

Amid global supply-chain disruptions and mounting pressure on fossil-fuel systems, India's diversification of its energy basket through diplomatic channels is both a pragmatic and an economic necessity. The oil and gas crisis during disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz exposes this vulnerability. Committed to securing its energy



INDIA IS ALSO DRIVING CRUCIAL INTERNATIONAL INITIATIVES SUCH AS THE INTERNATIONAL SOLAR ALLIANCE, CDRI, LEADIT AND CIRCULAR-ECONOMY FORUMS, SHOWCASING ITS CAPACITY TO LEAD THE GLOBAL ENERGY AND CLIMATE AGENDA

Shehzad Poonawalla is the National Spokesperson of the Bharatiya Janata Party, and Vijeta Rattani is development and sustainability expert

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needs beyond fossil-fuel dependence, India is embedding clean energy into external partnerships to build resilience against future shocks.

Second, in the new geopolitical reality, economic and ecological interests are increasingly intertwined and, in many instances, inseparable, and the Indian leadership is well aware of this. By cutting carbon emissions, adopting clean-energy pathways and investing in green technology, India stands to gain significantly in building a decarbonised economy and improving developmental indicators for its underprivileged sections through access to clean and reliable energy supply, cooking fuel, sustainable transport, decent jobs, rural livelihoods and improved living standards.

Third, securing convergence with European countries on clean energy and climate action reflects a shift in mindset. Historically, differences around equity and differentiated responsibility have defined global climate negotiations, with developing countries pressing for finance and technology while developed nations urge emerging economies such as India to act at par. The change in approach stems from changing realities and increasing vulnerabilities. Though India is one of the most climate-impacted countries in the world, Europe too is increasingly facing climate-related disasters and extreme weather in the form of heatwaves, forest fires, rising temperatures and rainfall anomalies. In 2025, Europe incurred losses of nearly \$45 billion due to extreme weather events.

The European Union has also significantly pushed environmental norms. Through agreements on joint projects with India in green manufacturing and technology, renewable energy and the blue economy, European countries seek to reinforce environmental standards and

strengthen multilateral frameworks. India, meanwhile, maintains its long-standing Global South position on equity while unlocking finance and technical expertise. Together, these efforts bolster a rules-based order with an emphasis on inclusivity, cooperation, partnerships and sustainable development.

India's diplomatic strength on the environmental agenda emerges largely from a wide array of domestic climate and environmental initiatives. India's decision to ratchet up its Nationally Determined Contributions (NDCs) underscores its sincerity towards meaningful climate goals. It has pledged a 60 per cent rise in installed non-fossil-fuel capacity, a 47 per cent reduction in emission intensity, and the creation of a 3.5-4.0 billion-tonne CO₂ sink by

2035, aligned with Net Zero 2070 and Viksit Bharat 2047. This is further complemented by the strengthening of grassroots institutions, the development of a carbon-market framework, infrastructure for a clean and green transition, ambitious capacity-building efforts, increased climate resilience, biodiversity protection and the conservation of natural systems. India is also driving crucial international initiatives such as the International Solar Alliance, CDRI, LEADIT and circular-economy forums, showcasing its capacity to lead the global energy and climate agenda. In other multilateral forums as well, India has pushed sustainability initiatives as key summit outcomes. This has helped generate global momentum in environmental governance, where India's approach is active, assertive and confident.

By aligning with European countries on green partnerships, India positions itself as both a beneficiary and a driver of the global energy and climate agenda.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

PIC TALK



A myna feeds its chick, at Mayong, in Morigaon district, Assam

PHOTO: PTI

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The Unfair grade: When the system betrays hard work



SAKSHI SETHI

2ND OPINION

There is a quiet tragedy unfolding in Indian classrooms, not in the form of crumbling infrastructure or absent teachers, but in something far more insidious: the gradual erosion of a child's belief that hard work truly matters.

Consider a scenario that is no longer hypothetical. A fifteen-year-old studies with the same dedication, the same late nights, and the same anxious anticipation as any other student in the country. Under one board, his efforts earn him 52 per cent. Under another, the same child, the same intellect and the same ambition secure 96 per cent and a scholarship. Nothing has changed except the system measuring him. Yet we ask him to carry the weight of that number for the rest of his life.

India has always embraced diversity in education. A nation with dozens of languages and hundreds of dialects

was never going to function through a single textbook or curriculum. Diversity is not the problem. The problem arises when diversity of syllabus translates into inequality of opportunity and is then justified in the name of federalism. When a student can score 96 per cent under one board and 52 per cent under another, we are not witnessing educational diversity; we are witnessing a failure of standardisation with national consequences.

In India, grades are more than academic markers. They determine access to colleges, scholarships, jobs and, too often, self-worth. A student who receives 52 per cent does not simply receive a lower grade; he often receives a social judgement.

Alongside this disparity lies another growing concern: the silent breakdown of digital evaluation systems.

Students and parents across the country increasingly report blurred scanned answer sheets, unexpected score reductions and opaque assessment processes despite claims of technological advancement. This is the particular cruelty of poorly implemented digital reform. It introduces the detached indifference of a machine into an already unequal system.

A human evaluator, despite personal biases, can be questioned and held accountable. An algorithm that produces a score without explanation offers no such possibility. Technology does not automatically create fairness. Without transparency, it merely accelerates injustice.

Perhaps the most overlooked aspect of this debate is its psychological impact. When students begin to believe that sincere effort cannot guarantee a fair outcome, something fundamental is damaged. Education ceases to be a contract between effort and reward. It becomes a lottery.

Mental health professionals working with adolescents increasingly observe that examination-related stress has changed in nature. Students are no longer afraid only of failure. Many fear that success itself may not matter because the system cannot be trusted. That is a far more dangerous anxiety to grow up with. India does not need a uniform curriculum, a single language of instruction or a standardised cultural framework. The richness of its educational diversity must be preserved. What India urgently requires is agreement on one non-negotiable principle: fairness.

This means robust moderation mechanisms that account for variations across boards, transparent and auditable digital assessment systems, effective grievance-redressal procedures, and institutional recognition that examination scores represent far more than data points. They shape how young people see themselves and their futures.

The real issue is not marks, but trust. If hard work is not fairly rewarded, the education system fails its most important test.

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

The writer is an educator and a councillor

WHEN REGULATORY FAILURES FUEL URBAN DISASTERS

The devastating fire at a bed-and-breakfast facility in Malviya Nagar's Hauz Rani area, which tragically claimed 21 lives on Wednesday, is yet another grim reminder of the systemic failures and safety violations that continue to plague Delhi's unauthorised commercial hubs.

The localities of Hauz Rani and Khirki Extension are characterised by extremely narrow lanes and poor ventilation, making them particularly vulnerable during emergencies. Owing to their proximity to major hospitals and commercial centres, these neighbourhoods have become a refuge for many families arriving from overseas. Over the years, the area has evolved into a vital support base for international medical tourists seeking affordable accommodation. Unfortunately, many low-cost guest houses operate without adequate fire-

safety measures, emergency exits or valid municipal approvals.

These infrastructural shortcomings are compounded by weak regulatory oversight. Despite repeated concerns, enforcement remains inconsistent and inadequate. Previous directions by the Delhi High Court for comprehensive safety audits have largely failed to translate into effective action on the ground.

While the government's announcement of ex gratia relief and a magisterial inquiry is welcome, such measures remain reactive. What is urgently needed is a coordinated crackdown on unauthorised commercial establishments, strict compliance with fire-safety norms, regular inspections and robust enforcement. Unless authorities act decisively, Delhi risks witnessing yet another preventable tragedy.

V REDDY KETHIRI | NEW DELHI

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LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Turning tariffs into opportunity

The proposed American tariffs on India, based on allegations of a failure to prohibit the import of goods produced using forced labour, warrant serious engagement. Rather than simply adopting a defensive stance, India must acknowledge the legitimate labour standards concerns underlying the US move. At the same time, dismissing such concerns as merely protectionist would mean missing an opportunity for constructive reform. If certain Indian industries genuinely rely on exploitative labour practices, the solution is not to shield them through diplomatic denials but to address the underlying violations.

India's negotiating position should be nuanced and credible. A meaningful response should involve three key measures.

First, transparent audits of labour practices in vulnerable sectors should be conducted, with the participation of independent international observers. Second, India should strengthen the enforcement of existing labour laws, focusing on measurable outcomes rather than merely introducing additional statutory provisions. Finally, India should engage with the United States through technical committees rather than political theatre, enabling experts to distinguish genuine violations from normal market pressures..

K SAKUNTHALA | COIMBATORE

Enforce fire safety before tragedy

The tragic inferno in Malviya Nagar is yet another reminder of how casually fire safety is treated in many of our cities. Time and again, disasters expose the same failings: missing or expired fire NOCs, overcrowded premises, blocked emergency exits, faulty electrical wiring and poor enforcement of safety norms. Yet, once public attention shifts elsewhere, these lessons are quickly forgotten. Fire safety must not remain a box-ticking exercise. Regular audits should be conducted by independent agencies rather than officials vulnerable to local pressures. Occupancy limits must be strictly enforced through digital monitoring, and violations should attract heavy penalties. Functional emergency exits, fire alarms, sprinklers and evacuation plans should be mandatory requirements, not optional additions.

Many countries have demonstrated that prevention is possible when safety regulations are rigorously enforced. Japan conducts regular drills and public-awareness programmes to ensure preparedness. In the United States and across Europe, hotels and commercial establishments face substantial fines or closure if fire-safety systems are not properly maintained. Strong enforcement, transparency and accountability are essential if lives are to be protected and similar disasters prevented in the future.

O. PRASADA RAO | HYDERABAD

Consent must guide rehabilitation

The Supreme Court has recently laid down an extensive legal framework to combat the trafficking of women while ensuring their dignified rehabilitation. The Court has rightly held that the consent of adult sex workers must be a primary consideration in any rehabilitation process. In doing so, it has challenged the paternalistic assumptions underlying Section 17 of the Immoral Traffic (Prevention) Act (ITPA), which often treats all individuals rescued from prostitution-related situations in the same manner, irrespective of whether they were trafficked, coerced, or had voluntarily engaged in sex work.

The judgment makes an important distinction between victims of trafficking and adults who have chosen sex work. It directs that, before a person is produced before a magistrate under Section 17, an inquiry must be conducted to determine whether the individual is a voluntary sex worker and whether she consents to long-term rehabilitation in custodial care. This is a significant step towards recognising individual dignity and autonomy. In a society where moral policing often reduces such women to either victims or offenders, the Court's emphasis on consent is both progressive and humane. The judgment strengthens rights while ensuring protection for those genuinely subjected to trafficking.

YASH PAL RALHAN | JALANDHAR

World Environment Day: Nature, climate change and the path forward

World Environment Day serves as a reminder of the shared responsibility to protect nature, restore ecosystems and build a cleaner, greener and healthier future for generations to come



SUSHIL KUMAR SINGLA

Historically, one invention and one discovery have led to many of the consequences humanity faces today. These are the invention of the wheel and the discovery of fire. While not the only causes, they represent the beginning of human interventions that have ultimately contributed to present-day climate change, much of which is anthropogenic or human-induced. Alongside natural factors, these activities have resulted in environmental impacts with both positive and negative consequences for living beings.

Awareness of the causes of climate change, its consequences, and the measures required to address both its drivers and impacts is widespread. Yet, collective action continues to fall short of the urgency demanded by the situation.

The answer perhaps lies in Indian scriptures and philosophy, which advocate not only respect for nature but also its worship. The sun, soil, Mother Earth, rivers, stars and planets have traditionally been revered as life-supporting forces. Ironically, human beings, often regarded as the perpetrators of environmental degradation, are increasingly becoming its victims.

As per the Environment (Protection) Act, 1986, "environment" includes water, air and land, and the inter-relationship that exists among and between water, air, land, human beings, other living creatures, plants, micro-organisms and property. This definition highlights that environmental protection is not merely about conserving individual natural resources but about maintaining the delicate balance that sustains all life on Earth.

Though the subject of the environment falls in the residuary list under the Constitution of India, allowing legislation primarily by the Central Government, states have made notable strides in the fields of environment and forestry.

For our country, where ecology and economy are closely intertwined, environmental challenges directly affect agriculture, tourism, water security and public health. Ignoring these challenges would mean compromising livelihoods and the interests of future generations. Despite its strong environmental credentials, India is not immune to emerging environmental pressures.

To meet these ever-evolving challenges, there is a strong need for scientific advancement in the technologies being used across industries. The country's leading research institutions, including IITs, IISc, IARI

TO MEET THESE EVER-EVOLVING ENVIRONMENTAL CHALLENGES, THERE IS A PRESSING NEED FOR SCIENTIFIC ADVANCEMENT AND INNOVATION ACROSS INDUSTRIES. EQUALLY IMPORTANT ARE NATURE-BASED SOLUTIONS, WHICH OFFER EFFECTIVE PATHWAYS FOR BOTH CLIMATE ADAPTATION AND MITIGATION, ADDRESSING THE IMMEDIATE NEEDS OF ECONOMIC DEVELOPMENT AND COMMUNITY RESILIENCE

The writer is Secretary Environment, Science Technology and Climate Change Government of Himachal Pradesh

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and CSIR, could jointly participate in developing indigenous technologies, taking into account the priorities of material and energy security, co-developmental benefits, and a life-cycle approach to understanding environmental and social impacts. Such collaborative efforts can be directed towards addressing industrial pollution and promoting the scientific disposal and management of solid, hazardous, bio-medical and e-waste.

While adopting global technological trends, attention must also be directed towards the adverse environmental impacts of such technologies throughout their life cycle of production, usage and disposal, eg, solar power and electric vehicles. To highlight just one example, the environmental implications of the increasing adoption of electric vehicles merit careful consideration, as their usage increases dependence on imports of batteries and rare-earth elements, while their substantially higher weight compared to conventional vehicles may contribute to greater road wear and associated particulate pollution.

Financing technological infusion is a major challenge. Besides government support, effective planning to facilitate participation in international environmental derivatives markets, e.g., the Voluntary Carbon Market, the Article 6 mechanism of the UNFCCC, CBAM and CORSIA, will help leverage green finance. Carbon capture, especially to effectively channelise the country's vast bio-resources for biochar and other such BECCS, offers significant opportunities for sustainable development and climate resilience.

To meet these ever-evolving environmental challenges, there is a pressing need for scientific advancement and innovation across industries. Equally important are Nature-Based Solutions, which offer effective pathways for both climate adaptation and mitigation, addressing the immediate needs of economic development and community resilience.

Alongside these initiatives, policy measures that promote sustainable domestic production of resources such as timber can reduce import dependence, conserve foreign exchange and minimise transportation-related carbon emissions. Environmental protection is not the responsibility of governments alone. Every citizen has a role to play. Conserving water, reducing waste, planting trees, adopting clean energy and supporting sustainable lifestyles are small actions that collectively create a significant impact.

Each and every action of human beings contributes to climate change, which results in an increase in average temperatures, changes in rainfall patterns in terms of intensity and distribution, and the onslaught of heatwaves. Holistically, it is not practically feasible to completely eliminate the impacts of climate change, but the only way forward is to reduce the pace of climate change and its resultant impacts on living beings and other entities.

World Environment Day serves as a reminder of the shared responsibility to protect nature, restore ecosystems and build a cleaner, greener and healthier future for generations to come.

India's economic growth under pressure in a world on fire



NEERA BALI

India may still officially remain the world's fastest-growing major economy, with GDP projections hovering around 6.8-7 per cent, but the mood on the ground tells a far more uncomfortable story. The ongoing and metaphorically perennial Iran-Israel conflict and the return of Trump-era geopolitical uncertainty are reshaping the global economy and pushing it into another phase of instability. Energy markets have been disrupted, investor confidence shaken, and volatility intensified across financial systems worldwide. India today is confronting the combined effects of global geopolitical instability and domestic structural weakness simultaneously.

The Indian economy is under visible stress, squeezed by global wars, rising fuel prices, weakening markets, a falling rupee, slowing consumption, and growing financial anxiety among households and businesses alike. Add to that increased import duties on gold, restrictions on silver imports, lagging manufacturing momentum, and repeated market corrections, and the picture becomes impossible to ignore. To put it politely, the mood on the ground is grim.

For India, these global developments are deeply consequential. Wars fought thousands of kilometres away are now directly influencing fuel prices in Indian cities, transportation costs, food inflation, manufacturing expenses, airline fares, and household budgets. India imports nearly 85 per cent of its crude oil requirements. As Brent crude surged beyond \$110 per barrel amid Middle East tensions, India's oil import bill ballooned sharply, putting pressure on inflation, fiscal management, and foreign exchange reserves. Every \$10 increase in crude prices widens India's current account deficit and pushes inflation upwards. The impact is immediate and brutal — diesel becomes expensive, logistics costs rise, food prices climb, and consumer spending weakens further.

In today's interconnected world, geopolitics has become economics. India's financial markets are already reflecting deep anxiety. The Sensex and Nifty have witnessed repeated sharp tumbles amid fears of prolonged conflict in West Asia, rising crude prices, foreign investor withdrawals, weakening global demand, and uncertainty surrounding US trade and tariff policies.

As of late March 2026, Indian equity investors have seen massive wealth erosion, with BSE-listed companies losing over ₹51 lakh crore (\$5.1 trillion) in market capitalisation since late February 2026. Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) have pulled significant capital out of emerging markets, including India. The rupee has simultaneously weakened sharply against the US dollar, breaching historic lows and intensifying imported inflation pressures.

A falling rupee is not merely a currency story. It affects fuel costs, industrial imports, electronics, raw materials, overseas education, tourism, and inflation itself. India today is increasingly vulnerable to imported inflation at precisely the moment domestic demand is already weakening.



Gold Duties and Silver Restrictions Reveal Economic Stress

Perhaps the clearest sign of pressure within the system is the government's recent decision to sharply raise import duties on gold and silver — from 6 per cent to nearly 15 per cent — in an attempt to conserve foreign exchange reserves and contain pressure on the rupee. Additional restrictions on duty-free gold imports and tighter monitoring of silver and precious metal inflows are not routine policy moves. They reveal growing concern within the government about rising import bills, pressure on forex reserves, widening trade imbalances, and the need to prioritise essential imports such as oil, fertilisers, semiconductors, and industrial technology.

India imported gold worth over \$70 billion last fiscal. In times of external pressure, such massive non-essential imports become economically sensitive. Prime Minister Narendra Modi's appeal urging citizens to avoid excessive gold purchases reflects the seriousness of the situation. When governments begin discouraging gold consumption in a country historically obsessed with gold, it signals underlying economic caution.

Headline GDP numbers continue to look respectable. India remains one of the few major economies expected to grow above 6 per cent. But headline growth is masking widening economic fatigue. Private consumption growth has slowed. Urban middle-class households are battling rising EMIs, stagnant wage growth, expensive healthcare, costly education, elevated rents, and inflation in daily essentials. Rural demand remains uneven despite government spending.

MSMEs and Manufacturing Continue to Struggle

India continues to project itself as a global manufacturing alternative under the "China+1" strategy. Sectors such as electronics and mobile assembly have expanded. Yet the structural weaknesses remain glaring. MSMEs — which contribute nearly 30 per cent of India's GDP and employ over 110 million people — continue to struggle under high logistics costs, expensive credit, delayed payments, regulatory burdens, and weak domestic demand.

India's manufacturing share remains stuck at around 14-15 per cent of GDP despite years of policy push. The opportunity is real. Execution remains the problem.

India requires a coordinated economic response involving government, industry, and citizens. The Government needs to ensure that supply keeps pace with demand, strengthen MSMEs, maintain fiscal discipline, reduce compliance burdens, accelerate manufacturing reforms, invest aggressively in skills and vocational training, and stabilise inflation. Industry needs to invest in workforce development, support smaller suppliers, expand long-term capital investment, improve productivity, and reduce dependence on short-term profit cycles. Citizens need to improve financial discipline, avoid excessive debt, increase savings, continuously upgrade skills, and support local businesses and entrepreneurship. The coming months will test India's economic resilience like never before. The challenge is no longer simply achieving GDP growth. The challenge is creating growth that generates jobs, protects household incomes, strengthens manufacturing, stabilises markets, and withstands geopolitical shocks. Because in the new global economy, a missile strike in the Middle East, a speech by Donald Trump, or a spike in crude oil prices can alter inflation, investments, and financial stability inside every Indian household within days. That is the new economic reality India must prepare for.

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India's broken exam system needs a radical overhaul



JYOTI K VERMA | PREM KUMAR KALRA

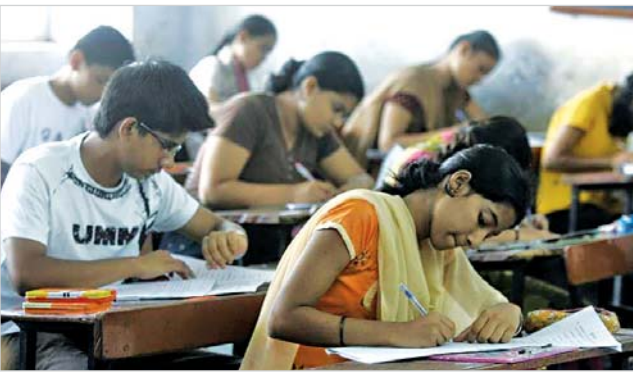
The recently published newspaper reports on the second NEET paper leak and glitches found in the evaluation of the CBSE examination call for immediate attention to the assessment process being followed in the country. There is a need to rethink or reimagine the system of evaluation to get rid of a bygone educational framework and save the future of our country. Last year, some recommendations were made by the National Testing Agency on NET, NEET, and CUET. But these recommendations are not going to serve the purpose. They will limit learners to rigid, quantifiable answers rather than evaluate reasoning, creativity, and understanding of complex issues. The technology of today, including Artificial Intelligence (AI) and Artificial General Intelligence (AGI), which use reinforcement-based learning, has immense potential to personalise assessments and analyse problem-solving processes.

Consequently, there are currently no restrictions on creating a question paper. Each question on the question paper can be different and

yet have an equal level of difficulty for everyone. Furthermore, by utilising AI and AGI, everyone can receive feedback on his or her errors and the marks that have been deducted. It is crucial that forward-thinking and futuristic approaches be used to show the rest of the world that Bharat is leading the way in education and assessment, while simultaneously raising student performance.

Multidisciplinary, interdisciplinary, and transdisciplinary education have all been advocated by NEP 2020. Therefore, any kind of restriction on course selection would never be fruitful. We cannot miss Tagore's vision of the "joy of learning" in the quagmire of searching for solutions to the leakage of question papers. Looking at the vastness of the country and the huge population of aspirants, we need to be more creative in our solutions. We cannot reduce exams and evaluations to a level of mere ritual. Due respect needs to be paid to the variety of ways people learn, think critically, and innovate. Frustration is writ large on the faces of students when they are made to run after scores at the cost of understanding and intelligence.

It is both an art and a science to determine what each student actually needs. Existing mediocre evaluation techniques, which mostly rely on examinations, are focused on rejection. This makes it much more difficult. Thus, the following are the main questions that must be answered: Do these tests fairly represent learn-



ing aptitude, critical-thinking abilities, and knowledge absorption? What criteria should be applied to evaluate the relevance of assessments? Can the mental processes cultivated by the taught subject be evaluated using the current evaluation schemes? What standards may be established to comprehend how learning objectives influence conceptual cognitive maps? Are students ready to evolve successful creative ideas and adopt novel approaches? It is truly painful that, after so many years of Independence, we still operate with a beaten one-size-fits-all approach to gauge a student's ability. Human development is far too complex for uniform methods.

Students need not be treated as passive receptacles of information, which Paulo Freire called the "banking model" of education. He wanted students and teachers to co-create

knowledge through active engagement. Such an approach would transform the role of assessments, making them tools for intellectual development rather than instruments of ranking.

Like Freire, Aurobindo Ghose's notion of "integral education" also considers evaluation as a reflection of a student's holistic development, not just his ability to recall information under pressure. In 1993, Professor Yash Pal's report, Learning Without Burden, equated rote learning with "the murder of curiosity". Expressing dissatisfaction with the current methods of evaluation, he said that essential skills like critical thinking, creativity, and inquisitiveness are being mercilessly killed. Further, in a country riven with social inequalities, Amartya Sen links rigid assessment structures with existing power dynamics, where marginalised groups are often deprived. For this, he blames systemic biases in education.

There is a need to explore various perspectives and tested models on evaluation. The STEAM (Science, Technology, Engineering, Arts, and Mathematics) model blends arts and sciences to develop problem-solving and creative thinking among students, breaking down the artificial barriers between different fields of knowledge. This is strongly reiterated in NEP 2020, which recommends project-based learning, portfolios, performance tasks, and formative assessments across all levels of education. There can also be a model that includes the appraisal of a learner's capac-

ity or capability through his or her role as a team member in completing assigned duties. It can be argued that students can continuously develop if assignments are given individually throughout the semester. On the other hand, if numerous assignments are given throughout the semester to a team, an individual, as a team member, may achieve better performance. Therefore, instead of being restricted only to objective, subjective, or group tests, assessment can be a combination of these categories to reach an accurate evaluation of each learner.

Group tasks are generally of two types. In the first type, one bigger problem is divided into parts. Each learner solves his or her part and then the solutions are integrated. In the second type, all team members work together to address the problem and then integrate the solutions. Both approaches play a part in assessing the learner both individually and collectively.

Thus, a reimagined evaluation system is imperative, as the current framework, with its fixation on rigid, uniform assessments, fails to capture the breadth of intellectual growth and creativity needed in today's world. This call to reform the assessment method is not merely an educational aspiration but a moral obligation on our part as academicians.

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Order Order

Thiruparankundram hill lamp row: SC dismisses plea for action against officials

The Supreme Court has refused to interfere with the Madras High Court order which dismissed a plea seeking action against officials who denied permission to Hindu devotees to light a lamp on Thiruparankundram hill but allowed religious celebrations during Ramzan. A bench of justices PS Narasimha, Aravind Kumar and Shree Chandrashekar refused to interfere with the order of the Madurai bench of the high court but reduced the cost imposed on the petitioner Hindu Dharma Parishad. "While we are not inclined to interfere with the impugned order passed by the high court, we are of the opinion that imposition of costs quantified at ₹50,000 is on the excessive side and can be reduced to ₹5,000 in the facts and circumstances of the case. Ordered accordingly," it said in its order of June 2. The bench said that the rest of the order of the high court would remain unaltered. "Rest of the impugned order shall remain unaltered. With this clarification, the Special Leave Petition is dismissed," it said. On April 9, the high court dismissed the plea for direction to the central government and Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) to instruct the Tamil Nadu government to take action against officials who denied permission to Hindu devotees to light a lamp on Thiruparankundram hill, but granted permission for religious celebrations of Ramzan on the hill. (PTI)



Delhi court convicts man for murdering DU student

A Delhi court has convicted a man for abducting and murdering a 21-year-old Delhi University student and destroying evidence. Additional Sessions Judge Swati Gupta was hearing a case against Ishtiaque Ali, accused of kidnapping and murdering Ayush Nautiyal, a third-year student of Ram Lal Anand College, in 2018. In an order dated May 30, the court said, "Detailed analysis of the oral and documentary evidence on record, it can safely be concluded that prosecution has successfully proved the chain of circumstances beyond reasonable doubt in the present case." According to the prosecution, Ayush left home on March 22, 2018, stating that he was going to attend a college fest. Later that evening, Dinesh Chandra received WhatsApp messages from his son Ayush's phone number, including a photograph showing him blindfolded with his hands and legs tied. (PTI)



SC dismisses plea seeking guidelines for time-bound disposal of cases

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to entertain a plea seeking framing and implementation of guidelines for time-bound disposal of cases.

A bench of Justices Vikram Nath and V Mohana dismissed the plea filed by a lawyer, who had also sought laying down of uniform, structured and enforceable guidelines for regulation of adjournments in all courts across the country.



The petitioner told the bench that the petition was seeking guidelines on unregulated adjournments of cases in the courts.

"You go to the Bar Council of India, State Bar Council, High Court Bar Associations and District Court Bar Associations," the bench told the petitioner, who was appearing in person.

"We don't want to take enmity with the lawyers. We are friends with the lawyers," the bench said in a lighter vein.



SC releases draft regulations on use of AI in courts

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move to modernise the legal landscape while safeguarding judicial integrity, the Supreme Court released draft 'Regulations for Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in courts', which contain a list of permissible and forbidden usage, stating that "no judicial outcome shall be reached through Algorithmic Decision-Making alone."

Inviting comments and suggestions from stakeholders and the general public by June 20, the Artificial Intelligence Committee of the Supreme Court provides for allowing AI tools in "case management (including identification of defects in new filings), cause list preparation, hearing schedul-

ing and docket prioritisation".

The draft regulations for use of AI in courts "shall apply to the use, deployment, or integration of AI in any judicial, adjudicatory or administrative function of the Supreme Court of India, High Courts, and all Courts including the Tribunals and statutory Commissions performing adjudicatory functions, within the territory of India".

The necessity for such a regulatory framework has become increasingly evident as the top court and several High Courts have raised concerns about the misuse of AI tools, which sometimes produce non-existent case laws that have even influenced actual judgments.

At the same time, the justices of the Supreme Court



have emphasised the importance of using AI tools to enhance benefits such as translating judgements into local languages and streamlining legal searches.

"These regulations aim to

govern the use of AI, grounded in the principles of human primacy, transparency, accountability, data protection, and judicial independence, while establishing an institutional framework for

responsible AI adoption across India's judicial system," the apex court said in its notice.

The 35-page draft proposes a clear "red line" for technology, indicating that while AI may assist, it will never replace the human mind.

According to one of the regulations, "the use of AI in court processes shall at all times remain strictly subservient to human judgement and judicial authority and every AI System shall function solely in an assistive capacity and shall not supplant or compromise the independent exercise of judicial authority by a duly appointed judicial officer and the ultimate authority to determine matters of law, fact and justice shall vest exclusively in the judicial officers of the competent jurisdiction."

Regulation 20 states that the use of AI for reaching judicial outcomes, such as judgments, sentencing, or determining the credibility of witnesses, is strictly forbidden.

All adjudicatory functions must involve a "Human-in-the-Loop" (HITL) approach, ensuring that final decision-making authority remains solely with a duly appointed judicial officer.

"No judicial outcome (including any judgment, order, or finding of fact or law) shall be reached through Algorithmic Decision-Making alone or solely on the basis of AI-generated information, data, or analysis and the human judicial authority shall be the determinative authority in all adjudicative decisions," it said.

Public employment must be given to eligible candidates as per prescribed qualifications: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Observing that public employment must be made available to eligible candidates in accordance with the prescribed qualifications, the Supreme Court has held that allowing a person with higher qualifications to secure a job intended for those with lower qualifications deprives a genuinely eligible and deserving candidate.

A bench of Justices Ahsanuddin Amanullah and R Mahadevan made the observation while setting aside a Madras High Court order that had reinstated a temporary bank attendant.

The top court said the high court had overlooked that the employee had secured an appointment to a post ear-



marked exclusively for candidates with qualifications up to Class 10 by concealing the fact that he was a graduate.

"Public employment must be made available to all eligible candidates in accordance with the prescribed qualifications....

uinely eligible and deserving candidate of the opportunity," the bench said.

The top court said the rationale behind prescribing an upper limit of qualification is both reasonable and equitable, namely, to provide employment opportunities to persons who, owing to circumstances of life, could not pursue higher education.

"The State, as a model employer, is justified in reserving certain categories of posts for such persons so that they are not compelled to compete with more highly-qualified candidates against whom they would ordinarily stand little chance of selection. Such a policy has consistently been upheld by the courts," the bench said while upholding the bank's decision to dismiss the employee.

Ashok Gehlot hails SC-constituted panel on Aravallis

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jaipur

Former Rajasthan chief minister Ashok Gehlot has welcomed the Supreme Court's decision to constitute a high-level committee for an independent review of the definition and demarcation of the Aravalli range, expressing hope that it will strengthen conservation efforts.

In a statement issued Thursday, Gehlot said the formation of the five-member panel on the crucial issue of defining and protecting the Aravalli range is a "welcome step".

"We hope the committee will prepare a scientific definition that



ensures protection of the Aravalli ecosystem," he said.

The Supreme Court has directed the committee to examine issues and "significant ambiguities" flagged in the Centre's report on the matter.

Referring to prevailing extreme weather conditions, Gehlot said protecting the Aravallis is essential for safeguarding coming generations.

"Given the severe heat and changing climatic conditions being faced by Rajasthan and the country, it is imperative to conserve the Aravallis, which act as a natural protective shield," he said.

He added that parameters used one or two decades ago may not be suitable in the current environmental context and the panel should take into account the present climate crisis while making its recommendations.

The senior Congress leader also criticised the Centre's policies on the issue, alleging that they had posed a serious threat to the existence of the Aravallis.

Gehlot expressed confidence that the committee's efforts would help conserve smaller hills and reinforce the Aravalli range as a vital natural barrier, the statement added.

HC protects personality rights of actor Naga Chaitanya

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has protected the personality rights of Telugu actor Naga Chaitanya and restrained the dissemination of pornographic content and AI-generated images portraying him in inappropriate scenarios.

Justice Jyoti Singh, in an interim order passed on Akkineni Naga Chaitanya's lawsuit, also restrained third parties from selling merchandise bearing his name and image without consent, and directed the removal of the objectionable content from online platforms.

Naga Chaitanya's senior counsel contended that several websites were hosting pornographic video content using the actor's name as a



category or tag, which was causing irreparable harm to his reputation.

He further said some parties were selling merchandise bearing his likeness, and YouTube videos and channels were carrying defamatory, AI-generated and other-

wise unauthorised content in violation of the film star's personality and publicity rights. In the interim order dated May 29, the judge said Naga Chaitanya is unquestionably a renowned actor in the Indian film industry and has the right to protect his

name, likeness, voice and image from unauthorised use by third parties.

"Such a distasteful content is harming and damaging the reputation of the Plaintiff and may mislead the public into believing what is depicted may be true. Plaintiff's right to restrain third parties from infringing and passing off also needs to be preserved," the court stated.

Several public figures, like actors Aishwarya Rai Bachchan, Abhishek Bachchan and Salman Khan, Art of Living founder Sri Sri Ravi Shankar, journalist Sudhir Chaudhary and podcaster Raj Shamani had earlier approached the high court seeking protection of their personality and publicity rights. The high court granted them interim relief.

2020 Delhi riots: Court defers verdict in IB officer murder case for June 11

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Thursday deferred its verdict in the sensational murder case of Intelligence Bureau officer Ankit Sharma during the 2020 northeast Delhi riots for June 11.

Additional Sessions Judge Praveen Singh was hearing the case against 11 accused, including former AAP councillor Tahir Hussain, and deferred the pronouncement of his judgment.

The case pertains to an FIR registered at Dayalpur police station on the complaint of Ravinder Kumar, father of Ankit Sharma. According to the complaint, Sharma, who was posted with the



Intelligence Bureau, had returned home from office on February 25, 2020, before stepping out again.

When he did not return for a long time, his family began

searching for him, only to be informed by locals that their son had been killed and his body thrown into the Khajuri Khas drain near a mosque in the Chand Bagh Pulia area.

Gujarat Police directed to conclude probe in two-decade-old criminal case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Thursday directed Gujarat Police to conclude its probe within six weeks in a two-decade-old criminal complaint relating to forgery and cheating in revenue records and said it is also incumbent upon constitutional courts not to remain mute spectators when prolonged investigations are brought to its notice.

A bench of justices Sanjay Karol and Augustine George Masih noted that in this case, there has been an inordinate delay in the investigation of the criminal complaint.

The right to speedy trial is

intrinsicly linked to Article 21 of the Constitution, it said.

In this case, a complaint was instituted by a man before the Judicial Magistrate, Bhiloda against four individuals under sections 120B (criminal conspiracy), 406 (criminal breach of trust), 420 (cheating), 463 (forgery) of the Indian Penal Code.

It was alleged in the complaint that the subject property was self-acquired by him in 1975. Subsequently, when he was on Haj pilgrimage from February 5, 2002 to March 21, 2002, the accused persons forged his signature and prepared a forged partition deed along with a bogus sale deed in relation



to the subject property.

On the basis of such forgery, their names were entered into the revenue records.

In 2014, the police presented a report before the judicial magistrate which

came to be rejected, and further investigation was directed, to be concluded within 60 days.

Later, the Gujarat High Court in 2017 directed preparation of the investigation report within six weeks

while recording that some of the material collected during the investigation had gone missing from the custody of the police station concerned.

The top court in its judgement said the high court should have taken note of the inordinate delay in filing of the charge sheet and intervened in the matter at hand.

"In the present factual matrix, nearly two decades have passed since the initiation of the complaint by the original complainant. However, it is a matter of serious concern that despite the lapse of such an inordinate period of time the investigation is yet to reach any meaningful conclusion.

NMC informs SC about stipends in medical colleges

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The National Medical Commission (NMC) has informed the Supreme Court that seven out of 756 medical colleges have not been paying stipends to interns, junior residents, or senior residents, and that show-cause notices have been issued to them.

A bench of Justices Aravind Kumar and P B Varale was informed by the NMC's counsel that out of 756 undergraduate medical colleges, there is no dispute regarding stipend payments from 573 colleges.

Additionally, 176 medical



colleges have been established recently.

"He would also submit that seven medical colleges have not been paying stipend for which the NMC has already taken steps by issuing show cause notices for levying of penalty and on receipt of reply further steps would be taken by them."

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Hyundai Motor India to roll out its first mass-market EV

Hyundai Motor India Ltd on Thursday said it will roll out two new models from the Chennai manufacturing facility, including its first mass-market EV, this year.

The company is committed to making Tamil Nadu its 'Flagship EV Hub for India', the automaker said.

Hyundai Motor India is committed to enhancing localisation across both electric vehicle (EV) and ICE (internal combustion engine) manufacturing operations and plans to increase localisation levels from the current 82 per cent to 90 per cent over the next five to six years.

The company said it is well-positioned to further expand coverage across all major cities and highways over the next 2-3 years, backed by a strategically distributed network of high-capacity chargers across key urban and transit corridors, in line with its plans to broaden affordable EV offerings in India.

The company also aims to enhance purchasing value from Tamil Nadu-based suppliers by approximately ₹4,000 crore, which is expected to create around 2,000 additional jobs in the state over the next five to six years. These efforts will significantly strengthen domestic manufacturing capabilities while reducing dependence on imports, HMIL stated.

Central Bank of India expects over ₹3,500 cr recovery from bad loans

State-owned Central Bank of India is aiming to mobilise over ₹3,500 crore from recovery from bad loans as part of measures to improve its balance sheet during FY27.

"We are having about ₹32,000 crore in technical written-off account. In FY26, the bank recovered ₹2,270 crore from written-off loan accounts. We are expecting ₹2,300-2,500 crore recovery from written off loans during this financial year too and it will play an important role in improvement in our bottom line," Central Bank of India MD & CEO Kalyan Kumar told PTI in an interview. During the financial year, he said, total recovery should be anywhere between ₹3,500 crore and ₹4,000 crore. The bank had made total recovery of ₹3,307 crore during financial year ended March 2026. The Mumbai-headquartered bank has launched special One Time Settlement schemes, especially for Agri accounts and also intensified recovery campaigns, including property expos and SARFAESI action. Kumar further said the bank plans to roll out wealth management and credit card business in second half of the current fiscal to ramp up its fee income. The bank has obtained board approval for the same.

"Now, we are in the process of issuing RFP (Request for Proposal) for onboarding those who are having expertise so that...we can start this business. In this year, I understand by middle of the year we should be in a position to launch this business," he said.

Besides, he said, the bank is planning to launch other products that can improve the non-interest income.

Govt moves to standardise edible oil pack sizes

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The government is preparing to introduce norms to standardize edible oil pack sizes, a move industry executives say could improve price transparency for consumers and create a more level playing field for manufacturers. The proposed measure is expected to address the growing prevalence of non-standard pack sizes, including 850 ml, 875 ml, 900 ml and 950 ml packs, which industry participants say can make it difficult for consumers to compare prices across brands and assess the true cost of products on a per-litre basis.

The initiative comes amid a broader regulatory focus on consumer protection, transparent labelling and sustainable packaging practices.

"We are pleased to note that the Government of India has

taken cognizance of this important issue and is moving towards addressing non-standardized edible oil pack sizes," said Vivek Puri, Managing Director of Puri Oil Mills Ltd., promoter of the P Mark mustard oil brand.

"For several years, we have consistently highlighted that consumers deserve clear, transparent and comparable pricing. Standardized pack sizes will help consumers make informed choices and ensure that competition is based on quality, purity and value rather than packaging

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | FRIDAY | JUNE 5, 2026

BUSINESS

11

Maruti Suzuki launches India's first flex-fuel car

Govt plans to establish 50 to 100 ethanol dispensing stations across Delhi-NCR and Mumbai-Pune-Nagpur: Puri

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Maruti Suzuki on Thursday launched India's first flex-fuel passenger car, the Wagon R Flex, at an event in New Delhi. The event was attended by Union Road Transport Minister Nitin Gadkari and Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri. The car is positioned as a step toward reducing crude oil imports and lowering carbon emissions by running on any blend of petrol and ethanol, from E20 to E100.

The launch event, held at Taj Palace's Durbar Hall in New Delhi, was organised under the theme "Fuelling the Vision of Atmanirbhar Bharat." Gadkari served as Chief Guest and Puri as Guest of Honour.

Maruti Suzuki Managing Director and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said the launch was more than a product announcement. "India has two national objectives:

From left, Maruti Suzuki India MD and CEO Hisashi Takeuchi, Union Road Transport and Highways Minister Nitin Gadkari and Union Petroleum and Natural Gas Minister Hardeep Singh Puri during the launch of the company's first flex fuel car in New Delhi

reduce dependence on imported crude oil and reduce carbon emissions. Flex-fuel meets both. It is truly Atmanirbhar and clean," he said. He acknowledged that a complete ecosystem for flex-fuel is still being developed, but said it was the market leader's responsibility to take the first step. "In the absence of an ecosystem, it is the responsibility of the

market leader to take the first step and encourage others. Today, Maruti Suzuki is taking the first big step," he said.

Takeuchi credited Gadkari for driving the industry toward biofuels. "When nobody believed in biofuels, you guided the industry that the produce of Indian farmers can replace foreign oil," he told the minister. He

Crude oil falls 2% in futures trade amid weak global cues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices dropped 2 per cent to ₹9,061 per barrel in futures trade on Thursday amid weak trends in the international markets.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the most-traded June contract declined ₹179, or 1.94 per cent, to ₹9,061 per barrel in a business turnover of 12,444 lots, snapping a three-day rally.

Crude oil prices eased in the domestic futures market after snapping three sessions of gains, after Israel and Lebanon agreed to a conditional ceasefire, brokerage firm Kotak Neo said.

In the international markets, Brent oil futures for August delivery fell 0.61 per cent to USD 97.21 per barrel,

and West Texas Intermediate (WTI) crude slipped 0.57 per cent to USD 95.47 per barrel.

The decline came after a conditional ceasefire agreement between Israel and Lebanon, which revived hopes for progress in negotiations to resolve the Iran conflict and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, Kotak Neo said.

Meanwhile, Israeli defence minister Israel Katz said the military will continue its ground operations in southern Lebanon, hours after Tel Aviv and Beirut agreed to implement a US-backed ceasefire to end hostilities.

Market participants also kept a close watch on continued risks around the Strait of Hormuz, which serves as the key transit route for nearly one-fifth of global crude trade, it added.

India to implement 2-3 FTAs in next six months, 3-4 more in 2027: Goyal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India will implement at least 2-3 free trade agreements (FTAs) over the next six months, while another 3-4 such pacts are expected to come into force in 2027, Commerce and Industry Minister Piyush Goyal said on Thursday.

He said that in the last three-and-a-half years, India has finalised nine FTAs including with Mauritius, New Zealand, the UAE, Australia, Oman, the EFTA bloc, the UK, the European Union and the US.

Trade deals with Mauritius, the UAE, Australia, Oman, and the EFTA bloc have already been implemented. Separate deals with the UK and New Zealand have been signed.

"On the 1st of June, the Oman-FTA came into effect. In the coming six months,

you will see at least two or three more very substantive free trade agreements coming into effect.

"Over the next year, you will see us executing at least another three or four significant free trade agreements and the coming into effect of all the nine free trade agreements over the next nine to ten months," Goyal said.

He also urged industry to invest long-term capital as

the early capital will obviously get the best of returns.

The minister was speaking virtually at the Citi India Conference 2026 in Mumbai.

Talking about the West Asia crisis, he said in the field of energy, the world has seen how India navigated the global crisis over the last few months.

When the world is facing severe inflation, India has been able to moderate it, he

said. "When the world feared a crisis, given our independence on the Gulf and the energy flowing from the Gulf passing through the Strait of Hormuz and also our major supplies coming from the Gulf, some of which have been badly affected and damaged during this West Asia crisis, India having already initiated the process of diversification of energy sources was quickly able to meet the needs of our countrymen so that through this crisis, we have been able to ensure uninterrupted supplies whether it is petrol and diesel, or aviation fuel, whether it's LNG to the factories, LPG to the domestic consumers," he added.

India, he said, has been able to ensure modest prices. The country continues to ensure availability of fertiliser to farmers, the minister said.

Tata Motors passenger vehicles should aim for over 20% market share by 2030: Chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian auto industry is poised for significant growth, and if it moves towards 60 lakh vehicles by 2030, Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles Ltd should aim for over 20 per cent market share, according to its Chairman N Chandrasekaran.

In his address at the Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles (TMPV) dealer business planning meet 2026 in Goa, Chandrasekaran who is also the Chairman of Tata Sons - the promoter holding firm of the Tata conglomerate - reiterated that the company has already committed significant capital investment of ₹35,000 crore by 2030 and will "recalibrate" the plan "as we progress", according to people aware of the development.

He told the dealer partners that from being told to exit the passenger vehicle business altogether and focus only on commercial vehicles in 2017, today the company is "now firmly among the top

2030, there is no reason why we should not aim for 1.2 million vehicles and over 20 per cent market share."

Asserting that the target is achievable with the right products, investments, capacities and execution, he said, "We have already committed significant capital investment — ₹ 35,000 crore by 2030, and this, we will recalibrate as we progress." To reach that level, Chandrasekaran said, "We must move from being a good company to a truly great company... Great companies are not defined by performance in stable conditions. They are defined by how they perform when conditions are tough."

Drawing sporting parallels, Chandrasekaran said, "It is easy to score a triple century on a 'flat pitch'. The real test is hitting a double century on a 'rank turner'. Running a marathon on a flat road in pleasant weather is quite different from running it uphill in windy conditions when both your legs and upper body are strained."

Silver drops in futures trade on weak global cues

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Silver prices dropped by ₹621 to ₹2.62 lakh per kilogram in futures trade on Thursday amid weak global trends and concerns that elevated crude oil rates could keep interest rates higher for longer by central banks. On Multi Commodity Exchange, the white metal for July delivery depreciated by ₹621, or 0.24 per cent, to ₹2,62,337 per kg in a business turnover of 11,830 lots. Analysts said the decline in silver prices came as renewed tensions in West Asia kept energy markets on edge, sustaining concerns that oil rates could feed into global inflation and delay any monetary policy easing by major global central banks.

"Silver prices are trading on a weak footing on Thursday, pressured by rising expectations that central banks may be compelled to tighten monetary policy in response to an energy-driven inflation shock linked to the conflict in West Asia," Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said.

'India should reassess FTAs, move to sector-based investment screening'

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India should reassess the effectiveness of its existing Free Trade Agreements (FTAs), modernise its investment screening architecture, and adopt a more coordinated trade and industrial policy framework as geopolitical fragmentation reshapes global commerce, a report said on Thursday.

The report said that India's economic strategy must move beyond reactive policy-making and focus on proactive integration through calibrated partnerships, stronger institutional coordi-

nation and clearer market access objectives. Among its recommendations, the report calls on India to audit existing FTAs, assess whether they have met intended objectives, and align future trade agreements more closely with industrial and export

priorities. It also recommended that India explore high-quality market arrangements and utilise multilateral institutions and bilateral investment treaties to secure greater predictability for businesses and investors.

The report titled 'Resilience in a Fragmenting World: India's Economic Relations with Great Powers' is released by Koan Advisory Group, in association with Chintan Research Foundation, the Information Technology Industry Council, and the Institute of Chinese Studies. "Trade agreements cannot be treated as ends in themselves. India needs a

clearer understanding of what each agreement delivers in terms of market access, supply-chain resilience and industrial capacity. In a more uncertain and protectionist world, evaluating whether our FTAs have met their objectives becomes even more important," said Shishir Priyadarshi, president, Chintan Research Foundation.

The report also addresses the contested question about economic engagement with China amid strategic competition and manufacturing dependence.

Rather than relying solely on geography-based restric-

tions, participants recommended a sector-specific and national-security-led investment screening framework, coupled with a phased strategy to reduce dependence on Chinese inputs where vulnerabilities exist, it said. India's manufacturing ambitions, particularly in electronics, clean energy and advanced technologies, remain linked to global supply chains that include Chinese capital and components, it said.

The report recommends utilising Chinese investment and technology in non-strategic sectors while strengthening screening mechanisms in genuinely sensitive areas.

Hindalco targets ₹1,000 cr revenue from aluminium window business by FY29

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Hindalco Industries on Thursday said the company is targeting a revenue of ₹1,000 crore from its engineered system aluminium window business over the next three years.

The business under the brand name 'Eternia' has been registering nearly 65 per cent CAGR growth over the last three years, the company said in a statement.

The company is eyeing over ₹1,000 crore revenue by FY29, driven by rapid cat-

egory growth, an expanding nationwide partner network and enhanced manufacturing capabilities, the Aditya Birla Group firm said.

The windows and facade segment in India represents

an estimated ₹40,000 crore market opportunity and remains largely unorganised, with premium segments growing at nearly 15 per cent CAGR, reflecting rising demand for high-performance, design-led offerings, the company added.

Satish Pai, Managing Director, Hindalco Industries Limited, said, "The building and construction sector is a critical pillar of India's growth story, and we see significant opportunity in delivering high-performance, system-driven solutions to this evolving market."

FROM THE WORLD

SINGAPORE

Indian jailed for forgery

An Indian National was on Thursday sentenced to 20 weeks' jail by a Singapore court for forging medical invoices over two years to obtain at least SGD 12,000 in medical reimbursement from his company's healthcare insurer.

Bhutra Ravi, 51, pleaded guilty to one charge of cheating, with another three charges taken into consideration, according to a Channel News Asia report.

The court heard that Bhutra worked as a principal consultant at Temenos Singapore, a software company, from September 2017 and was eligible for the company's healthcare insurance policy. He could also claim reimbursement of healthcare expenses incurred by his wife and children, it was told.

Between March 2023 and August 2025, Bhutra made fraudulent claims.

PAKISTAN

Four policemen abducted

Suspected insurgents have abducted four policemen along with their official vehicle in Pakistan on Thursday, officials said. The incident took place in the Kantani area in Balochistan's Gwadar port. Senior Superintendent of police in Gwadar, Ata ur Rehman, said that a search operation has been launched to trace four policemen who were in a police mobile on patrolling duty. "Initial investigations indicate that these four personnel were illegally detaining people going to Iran by road and moving them to a lock-up," he said. Gwadar port is one of the most sensitive areas of the restive Balochistan province, as it is the main focus of the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor.

LISA MASCARO ■ Washington

The House approved a war powers resolution that would halt the US military action against Iran, defying President Donald Trump as a handful of Republicans joined with Democrats to end the three-month-long war that has reordered politics at home and abroad.

House Speaker Mike Johnson had tried to prevent an outcome that would show the mounting opposition to the war, abruptly shutting down floor action two weeks ago when the war powers resolution was on the verge of approval. But displeasure has only grown as the conflict drags on and as Trump struggles to negotiate a quick resolution. The roll call on Wednesday was 215-208, and cheers erupted in the House chamber.

"This reckless and costly war of choice needs to end



today," House Democratic Leader Hakeem Jeffries of New York said earlier in the week. "All we need are a handful of Republicans to join us and we can end this

Pak rejects Dar-Rubio Iran nuke claims

SAJJAD HUSSAIN ■ Islamabad

Pakistan on Thursday rejected reports that Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar shared any information about Iran's nuclear programme with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio during their recent meeting in Washington.

Foreign Office spokesperson Tahir Andrabi was asked about reports that Dar, who is also the foreign minister, shared Iran's nuclear information with Rubio during their meeting on May 29.

Pakistan rejected reports of the deputy premier "exchanging any kind of information about Iran's nuclear pro-



gramme," Andrabi said. "No such information was shared," he added. Former Central Intelligence Agency analyst Larry Johnson, quoting an unnamed source, claimed that Dar had a conversation with Rubio that "revealed what Iran is prepared to do to preserve its independence", which allegedly "alarmed" the top US diplomat. (PTT)

Hezbollah rejects ceasefire, demands Israeli withdrawal

BASSEM MROUE/ JON GAMBRELL/ SAM METZ ■ Beirut

Hezbollah on Thursday rejected the latest ceasefire agreement reached between Israel and the Lebanese Government, demanding a complete Israeli withdrawal.

The announcement came as Israeli strikes killed at least four people, according to local authorities, and a UN peacekeeper was killed in the crossfire.

Hezbollah leader Naim Kassem, in a written statement read on TV, said the agreement's demand that Hezbollah fighters leave southern Lebanon under fire would mean "surrender, defeat and achieving the

enemy's goals." "What we are concerned about is an end to the aggression, ceasefire and Israel's withdrawal," he said. "We did not make any commitment to any party to stop resisting as long as there is occupation," he added.

The ongoing fighting in Lebanon, where Israeli forces have seized large swaths of the south, threatens efforts to end the Iran war and reopen the Strait of Hormuz, a key transit point for oil and gas whose closure has jolted the world economy.

Iran has demanded that any lasting truce extend to Lebanon. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu, who faces elections later this year, wants to press ahead with Israel's



offensive until Hezbollah no longer poses a threat. Israeli troops have seized around a fifth of Lebanon since Hezbollah began launching rocket and drone

attacks in solidarity with Iran days into the wider war. US President Donald Trump, who faced a rare rebuke from Congress on Wednesday, has sought to

downplay the diplomatic deadlock and the failure of declared ceasefires to end the fighting, telling reporters that in the West Asia, "a ceasefire is when you're shooting in a more moderate manner."

A Serbian peacekeeper was killed, and two other peacekeepers were wounded, when a mortar struck their location near Marjayoun, a Christian-majority town that has seen intense fighting, according to the UN mission, known as UNIFIL, and Serbia's Defence Ministry. Neither said whether the mortar fire came from Israel or Hezbollah. Lebanon's state-run National News Agency said a drone strike killed a motorcyclist and wounded four people in the village of Maaroub. (AP)

Nepal's foreign minister Shisir to visit India from June 5 to 7

SHIRISH PRADHAN ■ Kathmandu

Nepal's Minister for Foreign Affairs Shisir Khanal will visit India from June 5 to 7 at the invitation of his Indian counterpart S Jaishankar, the Government said on Thursday.

Khanal's visit comes amid a controversy triggered by Nepal Prime Minister



Balendra Shah's remarks in the parliament. Shah said on May 31 that apart from discussions with India on a long-

standing border dispute, Kathmandu was in touch with China and the UK as well. Two days later, New Delhi categorically rejected any role for third parties to resolve its boundary dispute with Nepal. Announcing the dates of Khanal's India visit, the Nepal Government on Thursday said in a statement that he will hold a formal meeting with Jaishankar in New Delhi.

Envoy meets injured Indians after Kuwait strike

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Dubai

India's Ambassador to Kuwait Paramita Tripathi visited the mortuary where the mortal remains of an Indian national killed in an attack on Kuwait International Airport were kept and met injured compatriots undergoing treatment at hospitals, as the embassy coordinated repatriation and assistance efforts.

The Indian national was killed, and several others were injured when the airport came under attack on Wednesday amid escalat-



ing hostilities between Iran and the US. In a social media

post late Wednesday night, the Embassy of India in Kuwait said Tripathi visited Kuwait's Central Mortuary, where the mortal remains of the deceased were brought.

The ambassador also met Brigadier Abdulrahim Al-Awadhi, General Manager of the General Department of Criminal Evidence, and conveyed appreciation for the "prompt and sensitive support" extended by the Kuwaiti authorities. "The Embassy is in touch with the family of the deceased Indian national and is coordinating with Kuwaiti authorities for expeditious transportation of mortal remains,"

the mission said. Tripathi also visited the Indian nationals also injured in the attack and being treated at various hospitals in Kuwait, it said. "She interacted with those injured and assured them of all possible assistance and close monitoring and follow-up by the embassy with the hospitals and their families," the mission said. The embassy had earlier expressed its deepest condolences over the death and said it was closely coordinating with the Kuwaiti authorities to extend all possible support and assistance to the bereaved family and the injured.

NOTICE OF RETIREMENT

[Pursuant to Section 32 read with Section 72 of The Indian Partnership Act, 1932]

NOTICE is hereby given that Mrs. Pramila Poddar has voluntarily retired from the Partnership Firm, "ORIENT EXPORTS" having its registered office at 70, Janpath, New Delhi-110001 with effect from 1st April, 2026. Henceforth, the firm's continuing partners, will solely manage, operate, and carry on the business of the Firm, any person, bank, or entity dealing with the Firm from this date onwards will do so with the continuing partners. Mrs. Pramila Poddar shall not be held liable, responsible, or accountable for any debts, liabilities, acts, or omissions of the Firm incurred after the aforementioned retirement date.

Sd/-
Date: 03.06.2026
Place: New Delhi

Vimal Kumar Poddar
A Continuing Partner

Baba Farid University of Health Sciences Faridkot

Ph. 01639-256232, 256236

Advt. No.BFU-26/17

VACANCIES

Online applications are invited w.e.f 09/06/2026 to 29.06.2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the posts of **Ombudsperson-01 on part time basis** under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot. For Application form, fee, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhs.ac.in

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

3108/12/2026-27/11974 Dated CHD :- 04/06/2026

Baba Farid University of Health Sciences Faridkot

Ph. 01639-256232, 256236

Advt. No.BFU-26/16

VACANCIES

Online applications are invited w.e.f 08/06/2026 to 28.06.2026 from eligible candidates through University website i.e www.bfuhs.ac.in for the recruitment to the posts of Assistant Landscape-01, Divisional Accountant-01, Psychiatric Social Worker-01 and Senior Assistant-05 under Baba Farid University of Health Sciences, Faridkot. For Application form, fee, Category wise distribution and other terms & conditions, visit University website: www.bfuhs.ac.in

Sd/-
REGISTRAR

3108/12/2026-27/11969 Dated CHD :- 04/06/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana, Sonipat

Corrigendum Notice

Tender No. 10-RCNK-OPN-QM-2026

Dated: 04/06/2026

Corrigendum Details

Corrigendum Publishing Date 04/06/2026

Tender Details

Tender No- 10-RCNK-OPN-QM-2026 (Open Tender)

Closing Date/Time-19/06/2026, 15:00

Name Of Work

Quality Management, Inspection work during (I) MLR of LHB coaches, (ii) Body Repair shop during MLR of LHB Coaches, (iii) SS1 of LHB Bogies, (iv) Shift Schedule (SS1/SS2/SS3) activities of Vande Bharat train Coaches

Website for tender-www.ireps.gov.in

Items Modified Documents.

Field Name	Existing Value	Modified Value
Documents	-----	Corrigendum to tender document

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

1906/2026

NORTHERN RAILWAY

TENDER NOTICE

Invitation of tender through E-tendering (e-Procurement Sytems)

On behalf of President of India Dy. Chief Mechanical Engineer, office at: Rail Coach Naveenikaran Karkhana Sonipat invites e-tender for below mentioned work:

NIT No.	14-RCNK-OPN-PTAMC-2026
Name of Work and its location	Annual Maintenance Contract (AMC) for 18 number of Josts Platform Trucks of 02 Ton Capacity at RCNK/SNP for a period of three years (As per Scope of Work)
Approx Cost of work	Rs.28,59,272.07/-including GST@ 18% (Rs. Twenty-EightLakh Fifty-Nine Thousand Two Hundred Seventy-Two and Seven Paisea Only)
Earnest Money	Rs. 57,200.00/-
Completion period of work	36 months (03 years) from date of issue of Letter of acceptance
Cost of Tender document (In Rs)	NIL
Date and time for submission of tender and opening of tender	Upto 15:00 hrs on 25.06.2026 Opening of Tender at 15:30 hrs on same day
Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in

Tender No. 14-RCNK-OPN-PTAMC-2026

Dated:- 03.06.2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

1893/2026

GOVERNMENT OF HARYANA

TENDER NOTICE

SR NO	NAME OF DEPARTMENT	NAME OF WORK NOTICE TENDER	OPENING DATE CLOSING DATE	AMOUNT / EMD (APPROX.) IN RUPEES	WEBSITE OF THE DEPARTMENT	NODAL OFFICER/CONTACT DETAILS/EMAIL
1	DIRECTORATE OF INFORMATION, PUBLIC RELATIONS & LANGUAGES DEPARTMENT, HARYANA	FOR HIRING OF MANPOWER AGENCY FOR PMU UNIT IN INFORMATION, PUBLIC RELATIONS & LANGUAGES DEPT. HARYANA, CHANDIGARH	05.06.2026 22.06.2026		https://prharyana.gov.in https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0172-5059101 dipritcell@gmail.com
2	PWD B&R, KARNAL	PDG. MAINTENANCE TO STREET LIGHT IN JUDICIAL COLONY, PANIPAT. + 2 WORKS	04.06.2026 10.06.2026	32.96 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01842265696 pwd-eeed-karnal@hry.nic.in
3	PWD B&R, HISAR	SPECIAL REPAIR OF OLD NH-65 INTERNAL CITY PORTION OF HISAR CITY FROM SAPRA HOSPITAL (RD 193.300) TO BYE PASS RAJGARH ROAD (RD 198.990) IN HISAR DISTRICT (ROAD ID 11549) (HISAR AND NALWA CONSTITUENCY) (CM ANNOUNCEMENT NO. 27824 DATED 20.07.2024) (PDG. SHIFTING OF 33 KV LINES ONLY)	03.06.2026 09.06.2026	114.46 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
4	PWD B&R, HISAR	CONST. OF 100 BEDDED HOSPITAL AT TOHANA IN FATEHABAD DISTT .(PDG. CABLING, 11 KV SUBSTATION, 250 KVA DG, UPS AND STREET LIGHT ONLY) + 1 WORKS	03.06.2026 09.06.2026	549.24 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
5	PWD B&R, HISAR	PROVIDING LIFT IN EXISTING JUDICIAL BLOCK AT TOHANA IN FATEHABAD DISTT.(15 PASSENGER LIFT) + 1 WORKS	03.06.2026 09.06.2026	71 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01662225651 pwd-eeed-hissar@hry.nic.in
6	PWD B&R, ROHTAK	AMC FOR VARIOUS ELECTRICAL APPLIANCES UNDER ELECTRICAL SUB DIVISION NO.1, ROHTAK FOR THE YEAR 2026 - 2027 (PART-1) + 6 WORKS	03.06.2026 10.06.2026	110.92 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9034929655 pwd-eeed-rohtak@hry.nic.in
7	AYUSH DEPARTMENT, KATHNAL	TENDER NOTICE FOR SUPPLY OF APPROX. 3500 WHITE ROUND NECK T-SHIRTS (160 GSM) WITH IDY LOGO (IN FRONT) AND SLOGAN (ON BACK) FOR THE INTERNATIONAL DAY OF YOGA 2026 EVENT	02.06.2026 11.06.2026	EMD 5000/-	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416544440 daokaithal3@gmail.com
8	PANCHAYATI RAJ, AMBALA	HGVY CONSTRUCTION OF DRAINS AND NALA IN RAJA GARDEN COLONY IN VILLAGE BARNALA, BLOCK AMBALA-II (RE-TENDER) + 1 WORKS	03.06.2026 09.06.2026	31.80 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	0171-2551368 prexeeng.amb@hry.nic.in
9	PANCHAYATI RAJ, SONIPAT	RATE CONTRACT OF PRINTING OF NOTICE FOR SPECIAL INTENSIVE REVISION (ELECTION OFFICE SONIPAT)	CLOSING DATE 12.06.2026		https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9416391006 prexeeng.snp@gmail.com
10	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, ROHTAK	REPAIR OF PATCHES OF KHACHROULLI MINOR RD 0 TO 45000. + 4 WORKS	03.06.2026 10.06.2026	34.63 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9896410404 xenfdrrtk@gmail.com
11	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, GOHANA	RECONSTRUCTION/CONSTRUCTION OF VARIOUS STRUCTURE FROM RD 0 TO 45000 OF BHALAUT SUB BRANCH	23.05.2026 15.06.2026	2055.75 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	9996532800 xenghn@rediffmail.com
12	IRRIGATION & WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT HARYANA, SIRSA	ESTIMATE FOR REPLACING OLD AND DAMAGED GATE AND GEARING OF HEAD REGULATOR OF SGC UNLINED CHANNEL AT RD 5800 IN MOUKHERA SECTION. + 16 WORKS	CLOSING DATE 10.06.2026	72.24 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	01666235721 xenghaggar@gmail.com
13	MOTILAL NEHRU SCHOOL OF SPORTS, RAI, SONEPAT	SWEETS AND PANEER	02.06.2026 16.06.2026	15 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8708859410 mnsrai@rediffmail.com
14	PUBLIC HEALTH ENGINEERING, MANDI DABWALI	MANDI DABWALI:- " DNIT FOR THE WORK OF CONSTRUCTION OF IPS IN UTTAM NAGAR, COLLECTING TANK (6.00 A-- 4.00 M), PUMP CHAMBER, BOUNDARY WALL, INSTALLATION OF PUMPING MACHINERY AND PROVIDING AND LAYING OF SEWERAGE SYSTEM, ALONG WITH ALL OTHER WORKS CONTINGENT THERETO " . CH. HEAD:- MANDI DABWALI- PROVIDING SEWERAGE SYSTEM IN NEWLY APPROVED COLONY AND CONSTRUCTION OF IPS AT UTTAM NAGAR AT DABWALI TOWN DISTT. SIRSA. + 2 WORKS	03.06.2026 24.06.2026	1589.68 LACS	https://etenders.hry.nic.in	8730000001 ee.mandidabwali@gmail.com

FOR FURTHER INFORMATION KINDLY VISIT www.etenders.hry.nic.in

RO 45902-I-27-7

INS AIRAVAT GETS WARM WELCOME AT COLOMBO PORT

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Colombo

Indian Naval Ship Airavat was accorded a traditional welcome at the port of Colombo, the Sri Lanka Navy said on Thursday. INS Airavat was bringing along critical spares for the Sri Lanka Coast Guard ship Suraksha from the Indian Coast Guard through a Government of India grant, said the Indian High Commission in Colombo.

"Visits by Indian Navy vessels to Sri Lanka aim to further strengthen the strong bonds between both friendly Navies, which is in line with India's policy of 'Neighbourhood First' and Hon'ble Prime Minister's MAHASAGAR vision," it said.

MAHASAGAR (Maritime Heads for Active Security And Growth for All in the Region) is the Indian Navy's flagship outreach initiative designed to foster high-level virtual dialogue and collaboration among maritime leaders in the Indian Ocean Region and the African nations.

9 killed in overnight strikes on Gaza, says hospital

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Deir al-Balah

Israeli strikes in Gaza killed at least nine Palestinians overnight, according to local hospitals, even as much of the world's attention was focused on the fighting between Israel and Hezbollah in Lebanon. The nine people were killed in at least four separate strikes in Gaza City, according to Shifa Hospital, which received the bodies. The hospital said the victims included two women and two children. Footage of one of the strikes showed a massive hole in an upper floor in what appeared to be a residential apartment building. The blast blew holes through interior walls and scattered blood-stained belongings across the room and into the street. "They say the war has stopped, but the war



A damaged apartment in a residential building is seen after an overnight Israeli strike in Gaza City, Thursday

has not stopped," said Walid Shbeir, the uncle of one of the men killed in the strikes, as family members sobbed over the bodies of the victims at the hospital. "Every night there is killing, and we have martyrs. Every night, in the morning, in the evening, and at night, this killing is continuous for us." The Israeli military did not immediately comment on the strikes. Last week, Israel killed the top Hamas military leader, two weeks after strikes that killed his predecessor. The fatalities were the latest in the coastal enclave since an October ceasefire deal attempted to halt a more than two-year war between Israel and the Palestinian militant Hamas group in Gaza. While the heaviest fighting has subsided, the shaky ceasefire has seen almost daily Israeli fire. Israeli

forces have carried out repeated airstrikes and frequently fire on Palestinians near military-held zones, killing more than 936 since the ceasefire took effect, according to Gaza's Health Ministry. The ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led Government, is generally seen as reliable by United Nations agencies and independent experts. It does not give a breakdown of civilian and militant deaths. Militants have carried out shooting attacks on troops, and Israel says its strikes are in response to violations of the truce or threats to its troops. Four Israeli soldiers have been killed in Gaza since the ceasefire. Israel launched its offensive in Gaza in response to Hamas' October 2023 attack that killed some 1,200 people and took 251 others hostage.

Iranian-French cartoonist Marjane Satrapi dies at 56



KHALIL HAMRA ■ Paris

Acclaimed Iranian-French cartoonist and filmmaker Marjane Satrapi, a prominent advocate for women's rights, has died at 56, the French presidency said Thursday. "Her passing marks the loss of a leading figure of French culture and an artist devoted to freedom, whose work carried a universal message and earned her immense international acclaim," the French presidency said in a statement. President Emmanuel Macron and his wife "pay tribute to a remarkable artist who transformed an Iranian childhood into a universal fable," the statement said. News broadcaster BFM TV and other French media reported Satrapi has "died of

sadness" a little over a year after the death of her husband, Swedish film producer and actor Mattias Ripa, according to a statement from people close to the artist. The French Academy of Fine Arts, of which she was a member, expressed its deep sadness in a social media statement, paying tribute to "a passionate advocate for cinema and film education" who earlier this year created a foundation to help international students come to Paris to study film. Satrapi is best-known for her monochrome autobiographical comic book and film "Persepolis," a coming-of-age tale set against the Islamic Revolution. "Persepolis" won the Film Critics Grand Prix at the Cannes Festival in 2007. (AP)

Canada, UAE condole Delhi fire incident

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Toronto

Canada and the UAE have condoned the fire incident in New Delhi that killed at least 21 people, including 12 foreigners, and left dozens injured. "Deeply saddened by the tragic fire that claimed at least 21 lives and injured many others in Malviya Nagar, New Delhi," Canadian Foreign Minister Anita Anand said in a social media post on Thursday. "Canada stands with India during this devastating time, and I extend my deepest condolences to the families and loved ones of those affected," said Anand, adding that she is in touch with her Indian counterpart S Jaishankar to convey Canada's solidarity. The UAE Foreign Ministry has also extended condolences and sympathy to the families of the victims, and to the Government and people of India, over the tragedy. "The United Arab Emirates has expressed its solidarity with the Republic of India following a fire at a hotel in Malviya Nagar, New Delhi, which resulted in a number of deaths and injuries," said.



Foreign Minister Anita Anand

Armed clashes erupt in Somalia's capital ahead protest

OMAR FARUK ■ Mogadishu

Supporters of opposition political figures and State security forces fought in armed clashes Thursday that erupted in Somalia's capital Mogadishu on Wednesday evening ahead of a planned anti-Government demonstration. No official casualty figures were immediately available from the violence that prompted calls for restraint from the United Nations and the United States as the Government and opposition traded blame for the violence. Residents reported heavy gunfire and explosions as fighting broke out in several neighbourhoods Wednesday. "We heard

heavy weapons fire, and people were fleeing their homes," said Abdullahi Mohamed, who lives in the city's Howlwadaag district. "Many families left the area looking for safer places." Opposition figures say the rally planned for Thursday was intended to protest what they call constitutional violations and efforts by President Hassan Sheikh Mohamud to extend his tenure. The Government has rejected those allegations. Mogadishu police said the violence stemmed from "organised attacks" carried out by armed militias linked to groups pursuing political interests. "The incidents were not the organization of peaceful



public demonstrations, but rather coordinated armed acts that directly threatened the security, order and stability of the Capital," the police said in a statement. State security forces repelled attacks on their positions

and launched investigations to identify those responsible for organizing, financing and carrying out the violence, police said. Opposition leaders accused security forces of attacking residences linked to former

Prime Minister Hassan Ali Khaire and former President Sheikh Sharif Sheikh Ahmed. "We are under attack," Khaire said in a statement. "For the second time in less than 24 hours, Hassan Sheikh Mohamud has directed armed forces against our peaceful gatherings." Traditional elders, politicians, and community leaders were meeting at Khaire's residence when the attack occurred, he said. The Government disputed that account. The UN expressed alarm over the clashes. Secretary-General Antonio Guterres said the violence resulted in deaths, injuries to civilians, and damage to critical infrastructure. (AP)

12 killed in fire at elderly care home in Sri Lanka; owner arrested

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

At least 12 people were killed and seven others injured after a fire broke out at an elderly care home in Sri Lanka, police said on Thursday. The blaze erupted at around 5:30 pm on Wednesday at the Mawpiya Sevana Elderly Care Home in Anguruwatota, about 65 km southeast of Colombo, in Kalutara district. Police said 10 residents were found dead at the premises, while two succumbed to injuries after being admitted to the Horana Base Hospital. The owner of the privately run



care home was arrested on Thursday as investigations into the incident continued, police said. More than 70 elderly residents were at the facility when the fire broke out. According to police, it was

the "worst" incident involving fatalities from a fire in recent times on the island. A total of 51 residents were rescued and have been provided with temporary accommodation at a nearby school.

Gunmen kidnap 7 students from school in Nigeria

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Abuja

Gunmen raided an off-campus residence in north-west Nigeria and kidnapped seven students, police said. The attack occurred early Wednesday in the Kaura Namoda area of conflict-battered Zamfara state, police spokesman Yazid Abubakar said in a statement. One of the students escaped and was in custody. The police spokesman said it wasn't clear where the students were taken but efforts were underway to rescue the remaining six. Zamfara has been a hotspot for armed gangs that carry out kidnappings



for ransom, with abductions of students increasing in recent years across the country. A tally by local news outlet Premium Times found that at least 1,900 students have been kidnapped from 20 schools since the 2014 mass abduction of over 200 schoolgirls from Chibok in Borno State.

Indian Army major wins two awards at US Army's advanced training course

SAGAR KULKARNI ■ Washington

An Indian Army major has won two academic awards at a prestigious US Army leadership programme that included 951 officers from the US and partner nations at Fort Leavenworth, Kansas. Major Prabhat Mishra of India received the Birrer-Brookes Award for Outstanding Master of Military Arts and Science Thesis and the General Douglas MacArthur Military Leadership Writing Award during the graduation ceremony of the US Army Command and General Staff College's Command and General Staff Officer Course (CGSOC). The awards were presented as 951 graduates completed the 10-month programme designed to prepare mid-career officers for senior leadership and staff responsibilities. The graduating class included 120 international military students from 92 countries. Among other international officers Major Aleksander Granberg of Norway received



Major Prabhat Mishra

the General Dwight D Eisenhower Award and the Arter-Doniphan Award, and Lieutenant Colonel Taleh SFHH Alrashid of Kuwait received the Major General Hans Schlup Award. Lt Gen Jim Isenhower, Commanding General, US Army Combined Arms Command and Fort Leavenworth, explained to the class that their responsibility as graduates of CGSOC is to be the conductor of the track, prepared by the academic rigour they conquered over the last 10 months. (PTI)

Beijing bans 4 New Zealand lawmakers from entering China

CHARLOTTE GRAHAM-MCLAY
■ Wellington

Beijing banned four New Zealand lawmakers from travelling to China for a year and demanded they apologise because they visited Taiwan on a parliamentary trip, according to a message from the Chinese embassy conveyed via parliamentary officials and shown to *The Associated Press* on Thursday. China has hit lawmakers from other countries with sanctions related to contact with Taiwan before, but it's the first time for New Zealand parliamentarians, the Government in Wellington said. Beijing has been increasing pressure in recent years on the democratically governed island that it claims as



its own territory. Two lawmakers reached by the AP on Thursday rejected the demand for an apology, while the other two could not be immediately reached. New Zealand's Government said it would express concern about the travel bans to Beijing. The elected officials visited Taipei in May, as New Zealand

parliamentarians have done "for decades," a spokesperson for Foreign Minister Winston Peters said in a statement. Beijing says Taipei has no right to conduct foreign relations and views visits by foreign lawmakers to the island as defying China's claims of sovereignty. China's Foreign Ministry spokesper-

son Mao Ning on Thursday confirmed the sanctions. "We urge the relevant people to sincerely respect China's sovereignty and territorial integrity and strictly abide by the One China principle," Mao said during a regular briefing in Beijing. "Anyone who crosses the red line on the Taiwan question must pay the price." Peters' spokesperson said the officials' visit was "not inconsistent with New Zealand's One China policy," which includes acknowledgment of Beijing's claim that Taiwan is a province of China. New Zealand is not among the 12 nations worldwide that have diplomatic relations with Taiwan's Government. Emails sent to the lawmakers by New

Zealand's Parliamentary Service, and seen by the AP, said that Beijing's embassy in Wellington had asked for a message to be conveyed to the four officials that they were banned from China, Macau and Hong Kong for one year. The ban might be rescinded if the lawmakers in question apologised for visiting Taiwan, the email said. "China has consistently opposed visits to China's Taiwan region by members of the legislatures of countries that have established diplomatic relations with China, including New Zealand, and this case is no exception," a spokesperson for China's embassy in Wellington said in a statement posted to its website Thursday. (AP)

Police warn families of Tiananmen crackdown victims not to visit graves on 37th anniversary

KEN MORITSUGU/
KANIS LEUNG
■ Beijing

Chinese authorities are snuffing out any remembrance of the deadly 1989 military crackdown on student-led pro-democracy protests in Tiananmen Square, which happened 37 years ago Thursday, in a further tightening of a yearslong campaign to erase what happened from public memory. Police told relatives of the victims they would not be allowed to visit a cemetery in Beijing on the anniversary of the crackdown, a person with knowledge of the matter said. The person spoke on



Police officers escorting activist Lui Yuk-lin on the 37th anniversary of China's Tiananmen Square crackdown, in Hong Kong

condition of anonymity because of fear of retribution. Relatives of the victims visited the cemetery on the anniversary for more than 30 years to read memorial state-

ments with police keeping watch, Amnesty International said. They belong to a group called Tiananmen Mothers. Hundreds of people, and possibly thousands, were

killed in 1989 as troops advanced through crowds that were trying to stop the military from reaching the protesters in Tiananmen Square, a vast plaza in the centre of the Chinese capital. The decision by the Communist Party leadership to send in the military was a pivotal moment in China's modern history, determining that the market reform that transformed the country into the world's second largest economy would not be coupled with political liberalisation. In Hong Kong, police stepped up security Thursday to prevent any commemoration at or near a park where

a massive candlelight vigil lit up the night every year until a clampdown following major anti-Government protests in 2019. On Wednesday, they stopped two performance artists from making symbolic gestures in separate incidents. One briefly held up a question-mark-shaped balloon outside a department store. US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, who recently accompanied President Donald Trump on a state visit to Beijing, issued a statement marking the anniversary. "No amount of censorship can erase the past," it said. "Those who sacrificed to uphold

their unalienable rights of free expression and peaceful assembly will be vindicated someday." Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning dismissed the statement as a smear on her nation's political system. "We urge the US side to ... stop using so-called democracy and human rights as a pretext to interfere in China's internal affairs," she said. Tiananmen Mothers issued an annual appeal for justice ahead of this year's anniversary. The statement, signed by 107 people, demanded full disclosure of what happened, compensation for the victims and their families and the pursuit of legal

accountability for those responsible. "The sacrifice of our family members is an indelible pain etched in our hearts. Our tears have run dry, grief is buried deep within, what remains is eternal remembrance of our family members and hatred for the crime of massacring the people," Zhang Xianling, a member of the group, said in a video message posted on Facebook - which is blocked in China. Amnesty said it is deeply troubling that China's suppression of the commemoration appears to be escalating. "Banning the relatives of people killed in the

Tiananmen crackdown from visiting their loved ones' graves is a heartless act by the Chinese authorities," Sarah Brooks, the organisation's deputy director for Asia, said in a statement. The Beijing Public Security Bureau did not respond to a faxed request for comment. Authorities in Hong Kong have banned the vigil since 2020, at first citing the COVID-19 pandemic. Simon Ng, a past participant, walked around the nearby Causeway Bay shopping district to mark the anniversary. "There are some things I can neither forget nor let go, so I have to come and take a walk," he said. (AP)

PROSPECT



DG CRPF, GP Singh, IPS, on his 3-day operational tour of Manipur, visited D/102 Bn RAF, C/129 & B,D/157 at Tuibong, Churachandpur

IndiGo suspends operations to 6 international destinations



India's largest airline IndiGo on Thursday said it has temporarily suspended operations to six international destinations, including Hong Kong and Krabi, as part of network optimisation. The budget carrier has decided to temporarily suspend services to Langkawi, Krabi, Ho Chi Minh, Hong Kong, and Shanghai starting July 1 and Siem Reap effective July 3 until September 30, IndiGo said in a statement. The decision has been taken in view of a traditionally softer demand in the upcoming quarter and an incredibly challenging cost environment, it said.

IndiGo will resume bookings for all impacted services starting October 1, subject to an improved environment, it said, adding that the airline stands prepared to reinstate these services earlier than scheduled, in appropriate lead time. The carrier also stated that it has managed to retain majority of its international operations – over 1,800 weekly international flights – despite this realignment.

"These measured changes are designed to align capacity with current market conditions and demand trends, while ensuring the airline maintains reliability and network integrity across its global destinations," the statement said.

Dhairya reclaims top spot in crossword challenge

Dhairya Pandey of Don Bosco Academy, Patna, has reclaimed the top national spot in the school category of the online crossword challenge, known as ACAD QUAD, for May 2026. Shraddha Shree of St Michael's High School, Patna, has retained her top ranking in the college category.

In the senior and global segments, Dharendra Tripathi of Ahmedabad and Harish Kamath of Bengaluru have secured first position, respectively. Nirbhay Raj and Abhishek Kumar, both from Dr Bhimrao Ambedkar Awasiya Vidyalaya, Pokhrai, Muzaffarpur, Bihar, have claimed the second and the third positions, respectively, in ACAD School. In the College category, the positions, respectively, have gone to Soham Sarthak Sinha of IGIMS, Patna, and Om Kumar Jha of NIT Manipur. Jacob Brahmakulam from Thrissur, Kerala, holds the 2nd rank in the Senior category, while N Rengaswamy from Chennai follows closely in the third spot. In the Global Challenge, Samit Kallianpur of Secunderabad and Ramki Krishnan of Chennai have maintained their praiseworthy performances by cornering the second and the third spots, respectively.

Shah chairs NEC plenary in Shillong

TONY DAS ■ Shillong

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday chaired the 73rd plenary session of the North Eastern Council (NEC), where leaders from the eight northeastern states resolved to work towards a stronger and more prosperous region and deliberated on the North East Vision Plan 2047.

The session brought together governors, chief ministers, deputy chief ministers and senior officials from across the Northeast.

"Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Union Minister for DoNER Jyotiraditya M Scindia, governors, chief ministers, deputy chief ministers, and senior officials assembled ahead of the plenary deliberations," the NEC said in a post on X. All the leaders reaffirmed their collective commitment to the growth, connectivity and prosperity of the region, it added.

Union Minister of the Development of North Eastern Region (DoNER) Scindia said all the leaders are united in their resolve to create a "stronger and more prosperous" Northeast.

According to an official communique, stakeholders from all eight northeastern states discussed the North East Vision Plan 2047 and key regional development priorities.

"The plenary session discussed and deliberated on



Union Home Minister Amit Shah in Shillong attending the 73rd Plenary Session of the North East Council

progress made by the CM High-Level Task Forces constituted for critical sectors of regional development," the DoNER Ministry said on X.

The session also reviewed important initiatives of the DoNER ministry, including updates on major schemes and programmes, outcomes of the North East Investment Summit and Bankers' Conclave, it added.

The ministry said leaders analysed youth-focused initiatives, efforts related to tourism and logistics, and the region's unique selling proposition (USP) projects.

Presentations were made on tourism, agriculture and horticulture, investment promotion, self-reliance in milk, eggs, fish and meat production, sports promotion, economic corridor development,

infrastructure and connectivity, and handloom and handicrafts.

"The deliberations are expected to facilitate coordinated action among states and stakeholders for achieving shared development goals," an official said.

The North East Vision Plan 2047 seeks to provide a long-term roadmap for transforming the region into a vibrant hub of economic growth, connectivity, innovation, sustainability and cultural prosperity by the centenary year of India's independence.

Earlier in the day, Meghalaya Chief Minister Conrad K Sangma welcomed Shah to Shillong for the meeting.

"Glad to welcome Hon'ble Union Home Minister and Chairman of the North

Eastern Council, Shri @AmitShah ji to Shillong for the 73rd NEC Plenary Session," he said. Ahead of the main session, a pre-Plenary meeting was held, bringing together senior officials from the government of India and all eight Northeastern states on Wednesday.

The meeting was attended by chief secretaries, state planning secretaries, senior officers of DoNER ministry, NEC officials and other key stakeholders.

The North Eastern Council, established under the North Eastern Council Act, 1971, serves as the apex regional planning body for the Northeastern region and plays a pivotal role in fostering coordinated development and strengthening cooperative federalism in the region.

Parliamentary committee on Railways reviews strategic infrastructure

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Guwahati

A high-level Parliamentary Standing Committee on Railways, comprising Members of Parliament from both the Lok Sabha and Rajya Sabha and chaired by Dr CM Ramesh, Member of Parliament (Lok Sabha), is undertaking a study visit to Gangtok, Kolkata and Rishikesh from June 4 to June 9.

The visit underscores the national importance accorded to railway infrastructure development, connectivity enhancement and capacity augmentation across the country, particularly in the Northeastern region.

As part of the study visit, the committee visited key project sites of the Sivok-Rangpo Railway Line Project

on June 4, 2026, including railway stations, tunnels and bridges, and obtained first-hand insights into the progress of this landmark connectivity initiative. IRCON informed the Committee that the 44.96-km Sivok-Rangpo Railway Line, which will provide the first rail connectivity to Sikkim, is targeted for completion by December 2027 and has achieved 77 per cent physical progress so far.

The delegation also visited the Rangpo Railway Station site and Tunnel No. 14. The Committee was accompanied by Chetan Kumar Shrivastava, General Manager of NFR, the Divisional Railway Manager of Alipurduar Division, along with senior Railway officials from Headquarters, NFR (Construction), IRCON and RITES Limited.



On June 5, 2026, at Gangtok, the committee is scheduled to hold an informal discussion with the General Manager, Northeast Frontier Railway (NFR), and the Chairman & Managing Director, IRCON International Limited, on the subject "Expansion of Rail Network in Northeast and Union Territories" with special emphasis on the Sivok-Rangpo Railway Line Project.

The interaction is expected to provide valuable insights into the ongoing efforts to strengthen rail connectivity, enhance transportation infrastructure and foster sustainable socio-economic development across the Northeastern region.

The study visit underscores the national importance attached to strengthening railway infrastructure in the Northeastern region. The discussions are expected to highlight the transformative role of railway connectivity in enhancing regional integration, improving accessibility and supporting socio-economic development in remote and strategically important areas. Upon completion, the Sivok-Rangpo Railway Line Project is expected to provide Sikkim with direct rail connectivity, facilitating faster movement of passengers and freight while creating new opportunities for tourism, trade and economic growth.

The interaction will also provide an opportunity to deliberate on cross-border railway connectivity initiatives and the unique engineering and infrastructure challenges associated with railway construction in the Northeastern region.

FAIFA calls for El Niño-ready farming in India



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Marking World Environment Day 2026, and as India prepares for an increasingly uncertain agricultural future marked by climate variability, extreme weather events and the growing influence of El Niño conditions, the Federation of All India Farmer Associations (FAIFA) on Thursday released a landmark report calling for an urgent transition towards climate-resilient farming systems capable of safeguarding food security, farmer livelihoods and long-term agricultural sustainability.

The report, "Inspired by Nature: El Niño-Ready Farming for Climate Resilience and Our Future," was released by Magunta Sreenivasulu Reddy, Member of Parliament, Ongole, Andhra Pradesh. The report presents a comprehensive roadmap for addressing some of the most pressing challenges confronting Indian agriculture today. It examines the growing impact of extreme heat, erratic rainfall, soil degradation, groundwater stress and resource-intensive farming practices, while outlining practical pathways for building a more resilient agricultural ecosystem.

Speaking at the event, Reddy said, "The Government of India has taken several significant steps in recent years to promote sustainable agriculture, climate resilience and environmental conservation through initiatives focused on digitisation in agriculture, natural farming, clean energy and farmer empowerment."

Delhi CM Rekha directs officials to ensure medical care, tight security for Kanwar Yatra

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Thursday directed officials to ensure round-the-clock medical services, stronger security arrangements, and improved civic facilities for devotees during the upcoming Kanwar Yatra, as the government stepped up preparations for one of the Capital's largest annual religious gatherings.

Chairing a high-level review meeting of the Kanwar Committee, the Chief Minister asked departments to complete all arrangements in time so that registration of Kanwar committees can begin from July 1 without delays.

The Chief Minister instructed officials to inform existing Kanwar committees in advance about documentation requirements and annual audit formalities to avoid last-minute problems during registration.

The meeting was attended



ed by Art and Culture Minister and Kanwar Committee Chairman Kapil Mishra, committee member MLAs Ajay Mahawar, Anil Vajpayee, Kartar Singh Tanwar, Sanjay Goel, and Umang Bajaj, along with senior officials from Delhi Police, the Revenue Department, Public Works Department, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Fire Service, Delhi Jal Board, DUSIB, and other agencies.

Officials from different departments presented updates on preparations related to traffic management, sanitation, healthcare, water supply, and security

arrangements for the pilgrimage season.

According to the Revenue Department, 308 Kanwar camps operated across Delhi last year. Officials informed the meeting that direct transfer of grant funds into the bank accounts of Kanwar committees and the introduction of a single-window system had improved transparency and reduced operational difficulties.

Public representatives and committee members reportedly appreciated the system, saying it helped streamline permissions and administrative procedures for camp organisers.

DDA extends last date of booking under its Towering Heights residential scheme

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority on Thursday decided to extend booking period for its 'DDA Towering Heights' high-rise housing scheme in East Delhi's Karkardooma, according to an official order. The deadline for booking under the scheme was originally end of March, which was further extended to May end.



"In continuation of the above, the booking period for flats under the said scheme has been extended up to June 30. This extension provides an additional opportunity to individual buyers as

well as government agencies for bulk purchase of the flats on offer," the order said.

Under the project management supervision of NBCC, DDA's Towering Heights has been designed as a premium residential address featuring a 48-storey, 155-metre tower, making it Delhi's tallest residential building.

It is the city's first housing project developed under Delhi's Transit Oriented Development (TOD) policy.

DAILY SUDOKU

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★☆☆☆

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

SOLUTION (4.6.26)

3	7	9	2	5	6	4	8	1
6	8	4	3	7	1	9	5	2
1	5	2	4	9	8	7	6	3
8	4	1	5	3	2	6	7	9
5	3	7	6	4	9	2	1	8
9	2	6	1	8	7	3	4	5
7	9	3	8	1	4	5	2	6
2	1	5	7	6	3	8	9	4
4	6	8	9	2	5	1	3	7

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

FRIDAY | JUNE 5, 2026

ACROSS

1 Initial letter (5)
6 Billy's stupid rhyme (5)
9 Attack mentioned by a sailor (7)
10 A wild throw can have some merit (5)
11 Might he cart around an Oscar? (5)
12 Show how to cheat? (5)
13 Save pounds - bits of money - on food (7)
15 An old hand at doctoring animals? (3)
17 Deity in authority (4)
18 Choose to figure in a terrible deed (6)
19 Does he get out due to exhaustion? (5)
20 It's not mentioned that hearty aunts get

DOWN

2 At a hotel, the silly fool may be a cleaner (6)
3 Producer of heady creations? (6)
4 A hush in the wood (3)
5 Like a friendly game of chess? (5)
6 Shirker getting even more lax? (7)
7 It's at church there's a sensation! (4)
8 Stolen from a game little fellow (6)
12 More than one blended harmoniously (5)
13 Turning away from drink (5)
14 The river seems a lot turbulent to

SOLUTION (4.6.26)

1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	
10								
13								
17								
20								
24								
27								
30								

ACROSS

24, Beeh-I've
26, Dr-ivel
29, Eve
31, Se-N-er
11, Lou
32, Dry-Ness
12, Tro-on
13, Borge-les
15, W-edge
18, He-n
19, Be-yon-d
21, Planter
22, Play
23, Asti

DOWN

1, Col-on
2, Roughly
4, Oars
5, Glow-er
6, H-one-y
7, Reign
9, F-o-g
12, Tennial
14, Lea
16, Do-use
17, Ed-Win
19, Be-Ch-er's

20, Spuds
21, Pa-y in
23, A-venues
24, Berths
25, Ivy
27, Ray-on
28, Vesta
30, U-sage
32, Dyed
33, Ind

BRIEFLY

Switzerland's Embolo seeks urgent World Cup visa



Switzerland forward Breel Embolo applied for an urgent visa at the United States embassy in Bern on Wednesday, one day after he was denied boarding the team's flight to the World Cup because of a criminal conviction.

The Swiss soccer federation at the team's training camp in San Diego confirmed why Embolo's travel approval to the US had been put under review Tuesday. He has a conviction that became binding this year.

Embolo was charged after an altercation in Basel city center in 2018 and his guilty verdict was upheld at appeal last September. The verdict was finalised in April, just weeks before Embolo was due to travel to the US for the third World Cup of his career.

"The embassy's inquiries focused specifically on whether any physical violence had been involved. This was not the case," the Swiss soccer body said. (AP)

ICC delegation visits Bangladesh ahead of BCB elections



A two-member ICC delegation visited Bangladesh to review the developments within the country's cricket board BCB ahead of its scheduled election on June 7.

The BCB is currently run by an interim committee headed by former opener Tamim Iqbal after the national sports council dissolved the previous regime led by Aminul Islam for alleged large scale irregularities.

"A two-member delegation appointed by the International Cricket Council (ICC), comprising ICC Board Directors Dr Mohammed AS Moosajee (Cricket South Africa) and Mr Tavengwa Mukuhani (Zimbabwe Cricket), recently visited Bangladesh to engage with a range of stakeholders to review developments linked to the Bangladesh Cricket Board (BCB). "The ICC wishes to clarify that the delegation will submit its findings and observations to the ICC Board in due course and will not be making any media comment on the matter," said the ICC in a statement.

It was also under Aminul Islam's tenure that BCB had decided to pull out of the T20 World Cup in India in retaliation to BCCI's instruction to KKR for removing senior pacer Mustafizur Raham from their IPL 2026 roster. (PTI)

Sindhu exits Indonesia Open after loss to An Se Young



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Jakarta

Two-time Olympic medallist PV Sindhu suffered a second successive defeat to world No. 1 An Se Young in as many weeks to bow out of the Indonesia Open here on Thursday. Sindhu, who had also lost to the South Korean in the quarterfinals of last week's Singapore Open, showed spark but only in patches to go down 17-21, 14-21 in the round of 16 clash.

The defeat extended Sindhu's losing streak against the reigning Olympic champion to 10 matches. The Indian is yet to register a win over An.

The contest began on an even footing, with the scores locked at 10-10 midway through the opening game as Sindhu showcased glimpses of her best form and managed to put the Korean under pressure at times. She briefly edged ahead at 15-14 with some aggressive strokeplay, but An responded in trademark fashion, reeling off a series of points to take a 19-16 lead. The Korean then won two consecutive points, including a gruelling 41-shot rally, to seal the opening game.

An carried that momentum into the second game, moving smoothly around the court and racing to a 13-6 lead.

Despite finding herself on the back foot, Sindhu continued to fight for every point and narrowed the gap on a few occasions. However, An's consistency and court coverage proved decisive as she closed out the match to advance to quarterfinals.

Argentina's World Cup title defense draws a frenzy in Kansas City

DAVE SKRETTAAP ■ Kansas City

Turns out that reigning World Cup champion Argentina draws quite a crowd no matter where it goes.

Whether it be fans surrounding the team's upscale hotel near downtown Kansas City, or their first training session opened to media Wednesday that drew hundreds of reporters to the facilities of Major League Soccer club Sporting Kansas City, there are few places that Lionel Messi and the rest of La Albiceleste are not the center of attention as the tournament draws near. They begin their title



defense against Algeria at Arrowhead Stadium on June 16.

Argentina coach Lionel Scaloni revealed his 26-man World Cup roster last week. It is headlined by Messi, who turns 39 in less than a month, and features 17 players that were on the team that triumphed four years ago against France in the final in Qatar. Messi has been dealing with muscle fatigue and a mild strain in his left hamstring. The team has said his recovery time will depend on "his clinical and functional progress," though it seems unlikely that he will participate in its upcoming friend-

lies. He came to the practice field after the rest of the team on Wednesday and did some conditioning work off to the side.

Argentina did not make any players or coaches available to speak to reporters. The team will continue training in Kansas City until it departs for the first of two World Cup tune-up matches against Honduras on Saturday in College Station, Texas.

The team plays Iceland in Auburn, Alabama, three days later before resuming its training in Kansas City.

Most of the players arrived at the team's home base Sunday aboard a charter from Buenos Aires designed to pay homage to the nation's rich World Cup history. The flight number 1978 was a nod to the year it beat the Netherlands to win the title, and the A330 was trimmed with special livery that included the national team colors and Messi's No. 10 on the tail.

Messi joined the team on a separate charter from Florida a few hours later.

The entire roster got a dose of

Midwestern hospitality from hundreds of fans who waited outside the Origin Hotel to greet them, then they got a big taste of summer life in tornado alley when sirens sounded after midnight and a heavy storm rolled through.

High winds and lashing rain knocked over several tents and fences that had been put up for security.

"When they pick you as their training site for defending the World Cup, and this is where they are for the next - you know, hopefully through the end of the tournament - it's surreal," said Jake Reid, the president and CEO of Sporting Kansas City, who watched the open training session with a series of dignitaries that included Kansas City, Missouri, Mayor Quinton Lucas.

"When they landed on Sunday," Reid said, "it started to get real for sure." Weather notwithstanding, the central location of Kansas City has made it a favorable destination for World Cup base camps. (AP)



All-Italian semifinal at French Open on cards

ANDREW DAMPFAP ■ Paris

An Italian man will be in the French Open final and it's not Jannik Sinner.

Not Lorenzo Musetti, either.

Flavio Cobolli will play fellow Italian Matteo Arnaldi on Friday in the first Grand Slam semifinal for both players.

Cobolli beat Felix Auger-Aliassime 4-6, 6-4, 6-4, 6-4 and Arnaldi advanced when Matteo Berrettini, yet another Italian, retired because of an injury to his left hip with Arnaldi leading 7-5, 5-2 on Wednesday.

Berrettini had received treatment during a medical timeout earlier in the second set.

"We have to be happy for Italian tennis," Cobolli said.

While Sinner and Musetti were both in the last four a year ago, they were on opposite sides of the draw, meaning it will mark the first all-Italian men's semifinal in Grand Slam history.

It's been exactly 50 years since an Italian man won



the French Open and 1976 champion Adriano Panatta was asked before the tournament to present the Coupe des Mousquetaires trophy this year. Cobolli comes from the same tennis club in Rome as Panatta, the Tennis Club Parioli.

Arnaldi said he first played Cobolli in the Italian under-14 championship:

"We are good friends."

Second-seeded Alexander Zverev and No. 26 Jakob Mensik will meet in the other semifinal.

While Italian tennis is booming, the 14th-ranked Cobolli, No. 104 Arnaldi and No. 105 Berrettini were not the Azzurri expected to get this far.

Top-ranked Sinner came

to Paris on a 29-match winning streak and seemed destined to take the title after wasting three match points in the final against Carlos Alcaraz last year.

Musetti didn't make it back to Roland Garros this year due to an injury.

But Cobolli, who at 24 is the same age as Sinner and Musetti, has dropped just two sets in five matches.

On a windy day inside Court Philippe-Chatrier, Auger-Aliassime whiffed on an overhead during the very first point of the match and also appeared disturbed when loud music was turned on accidentally over the stadium speakers during a key point later in the third set.

Still, the Canadian won the opening set - after which Cobolli left the court to regain his composure.

"I went to the toilet to think a bit, to change something," Cobolli said. "I just said to myself to fight, because I felt like this is the chance of my life and I have to give everything." (AP)

Ministry acts on suggestions of Gopichand-led Task Force



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Acting on the Pullela Gopichand-led Task Force's recommendations for coaching reforms, Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya on Thursday said plans are afoot to create a National Coach Accreditation Board (NCAB) for "standardisation of coaching quality across the country."

The Ministry-appointed nine-member Task Force had recommended a Target Olympic Podium Scheme (TOPS) for coaches and NCAB as the apex body for their education, accreditation and governance. The 43-page report was submitted to the Sports Ministry in January.

"Moving forward we would also integrate coaching with sports sciences. I believe sports science is not being optimally used as of now because there is a reluctance on part of coaches to implement new suggestions," Mandaviya said in an interaction with the media here.

The Gopichand-led panel had recommended that NCAB should comprise the Indian Olympic Association President, the Sports Secretary, a person of national eminence with "cross-ministerial influence", and an eminent academician with expertise in pedagogy and educational systems.

"The National Coach Accreditation Board will

become the central nervous system of India's coaching ecosystem - setting standards, ensuring accountability, and unifying government, federations, educational institutions, and the Olympic movement," the report had stated.

Currently, the coaching training in Olympic sports is primarily through diploma courses on offer at the Netaji Subhash National Institute of Sports in Patiala.

The Task Force had described India's coaching ecosystem as fragmented, inconsistent, and heavily reliant on individual effort rather than institutional strength and advocated primacy to coaches' authority over athlete "discomfort" when "training becomes difficult".

The ministry said a "governance structure and roadmap" are being prepared for the implementation of NCAB besides the establishment of a National Coach Registry, an Accreditation Portal and a dedicated helpline for coaches.

The ministry hoped that once implemented, it would create a "transparent, accountable, and globally competitive coaching ecosystem."

Expansion of the Coaching Pool: The Minister said he is aiming to fill up the over 700 vacant coaching slots in the Sports Authority of India by the end of this year.

India eye turnaround in FIFA friendly against Tajikistan

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Hisor (Tajikistan)

After being deflated by back-to-back defeats in the Unity Cup last month, India's beleaguered football team would need all the resilience it can muster to outwit a rising Tajikistan when the two sides clash in a FIFA international friendly here on Friday.

For inspiration, the Indians can draw from their win against the same opponents last year in the CAFA Nations Cup.

But coming in for Friday's game, India have lost to Jamaica (0-2) and Zimbabwe (0-1) in the Unity Cup in London on May 27 and 30 respectively, before arriving here for two matches against Tajikistan in the current FIFA international window (June 1-9). The second match will also be



played here on Sunday.

India's 2-1 win over Tajikistan on August 29 last year during the CAFA Nations Cup at the same

venue of Hisor Central Stadium was head coach Khalid Jamil's first match in charge of the team. India had finished third in

that tournament, after beating Oman in a penalty shootout.

But India could win only once in the next six matches, losing to the likes of Bangladesh and Singapore. Pressure has been piling on Jamil under whom India have won just three matches out of 10 so far.

India played the Unity Cup without seven Mohun Bagan Super Giant players after the club refused to release them at the eleventh hour on the ground that the tournament was being held outside the FIFA window.

The same controversy was triggered during the CAFA Nations Cup last year when MBSG refused to release seven players.

The two international friendly matches are being held inside the FIFA window but Mohun Bagan Super Giant players will not feature in them.

Sri Lanka beats West Indies by 41 runs

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Kingston (Jamaica)

Pathum Nissanka made a careful 79 and captain Kusal Mendis a fast-paced 72 to lay the foundation for Sri Lanka's 41-run win Wednesday over the West Indies in the first one-day cricket international.

Nissanka and Mendis put on 136 for the second wicket and with contributions of 45 by Charith Asalanka and an unbeaten 44 by Janith Liyanage, Sri Lanka reached 307-7 after being asked to bat.

Captain Shai Hope carried the fight to Sri Lanka with an innings of 56 from 66 balls and opener Justin Greaves made 45 from 38 balls, but the West Indies' were all out for 262 in the final over.

After partnerships of 50 for the first wicket and 52 for the third, wickets fell regularly and the required run-rate climbed. There was still hope when Roston Chase was at the crease but his innings of 33 ended when he was bowled by Dushmantha Chameera who



took 4-67.

The West Indies won the toss and chose to bowl first on a pitch that looked likely to favor slower bowlers. They made an early breakthrough when Kamindu Mendis was out for 12 in the seventh over. **Strong partnership:** Nissanka and Mendis came together at that point and carried Sri Lanka to 158-2 before Mendis was out for 72 for 62

balls. Opener Nissanka carried on briefly before falling for 79 from 102 balls.

The West Indies needed to pick up wickets in the middle overs but Asalanka and Liyanage provided stiff resistance, putting on 64 for the fifth wicket.

Hope was out with the West Indies total 167-5 in the 31st over but from them the resistance faded.

Congo's soccer team seeks alternatives amid Ebola crisis

ASSOCIATED PRESS ■ Madrid

Congo was still hoping to play its World Cup warmup against Chile after the mayor of the Spanish city of La Linea de la Concepcion denied authorization for the match because of health concerns related to the Ebola crisis. Congo's soccer federation said it was in discussions with the Spanish soccer federation and relevant international bodies to find solutions.

Government authorities in the southern city of La Linea de la Concepcion announced the decision to not authorize next Tuesday's friendly citing possible health risks linked to the Ebola crisis. Congo was playing a warmup against Denmark in Liege, Belgium,



on Wednesday.

An outbreak of a rare type of Ebola virus has plagued Congo and Uganda. The World Health Organisation has declared it a public health emergency of international concern.

Congo had already canceled a three-day World Cup preparation training camp

and a planned farewell to fans in the capital Kinshasa because of the outbreak the eastern part of the country.

All of the Congo players and the team's French coach, Sebastien Desabre, are based outside of the central African country with most of them playing in France.



Kohli out of Afghanistan ODIs with hamstring injury



BHARAT SHARMA ■ New Delhi

Indian batting superstar Virat Kohli was on Thursday ruled out of the upcoming ODI series against Afghanistan due to a hamstring injury that he sustained during the recently-concluded IPL.

The three-match series begins on June 13 in Dharamsala. Kohli suffered the injury during the IPL final that his side Royal Challengers Bengaluru won on Sunday.

"He is out of the ODI series due to a hamstring injury. He got injured during the final. Scans have revealed distal semimembranosus tendon tear," a BCCI source told PTI.

A distal semimembranosus tendon tear is a rare hamstring injury affecting the thick tendon that attaches a muscle to the inner part of the shin-

bone, just below the knee.

Kohli, known for his unmatched fitness even at 37 years of age, was in stellar form in the IPL where he steered Royal Challengers Bengaluru to a second consecutive title. He hit the winning runs in the final against Gujarat Titans.

Reinventing his T20 game, Kohli amassed 675 runs in RCB's triumphant campaign including a hundred and five fifty plus scores. Kohli's absence will take the sheen off the upcoming series.

Though the former India captain is now a one-format player, he remains a top draw for fans worldwide. It is extremely rare for Kohli to miss games due to an injury, given his exemplary



fitness standards.

It also remains to be seen if Rohit Sharma is available for the whole series against Afghanistan. The opener was included in the squad subject to fitness after a hamstring injury affected his IPL appearances. Ever since both Kohli and Rohit retired from Tests last year, there has been immense speculation on their ODI future.

The next 50-over World Cup is scheduled in South Africa in October-November 2027 and they would be included in the squad on the basis of their form and fitness leading up to the tournament.

The second ODI against Afghanistan will be played in Lucknow on June 17 followed by the third and final match in Chennai on June 20.

After the Afghanistan series, India's next ODI assignment will be in England — three games beginning from July 14. (PTI)

PCI wants CBI probe into para athlete's murder; writes to minister



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Paralympic Committee of India (PCI) President Devendra Jhajharia has urged Sports Minister Mansukh Mandaviya to seek a CBI probe into the murder of para-athlete Chirag Tyagi, saying the case has "deeply shaken" the country's para-sports community. Tyagi was found dead near Sai Upvan in Ghaziabad on May 30. He was a resident of Basantpur Sethli village in Muradnagar, Uttar Pradesh. According to police, Tyagi, who was a national level gold medalist and had also qualified for this year's Asian Games, was shot dead and another para-athlete Yash Khatik, has been detained.

"I am writing to bring to your urgent attention the tragic murder of Para Athlete Chirag Tyagi. Class T12 (visually disable), from Uttar Pradesh State, whose untimely death has deeply shaken the para-sports community," Jhajharia wrote in his letter addressed to Mandaviya dated June 3. "The circumstances surrounding his death raise serious concerns that merit an impartial and thorough investigation. Given the gravity of the matter and the need to ensure public confidence in the delivery of justice, the PCI respectfully requests your intervention to recommend a CBI investigation into the murder of Chirag Tyagi," the letter read.

A sports ministry source, however, said law and order is a state subject and it is upto the Uttar Pradesh government to take a call on this matter. "Law and order is a state subject. The Sports Ministry cannot make any such recommendation," a ministry source said. Police investigation revealed that Tyagi had lodged a complaint against Khatik during a document verification process. Following the complaint, Khatik's eligibility was cancelled, leading to a desire for revenge.

We need to stick to a Number 3: Doeschate

KUSHAN SARKAR ■ Mullanpur

India's assistant coach Ryan Ten Doeschate conceded that too many players have batted at number three in Test matches after Cheteshwar Pujara's retirement and it was time that either Sai Sudharsan or Devdutt Padikkal is given a long rope at the key batting position.

Pujara announced his retirement in 2025 but last played in white flannels for India in the WTC final in 2023. Since then Shubman Gill, Padikkal, Sudharsan, Karun Nair and Washington Sundar have all been tried in that position. Sudharsan has played six Tests and has managed a not-so-impressive average of 27 plus.

"There's been a lot of changes in that spot and that's not ideal, you know. You need to look at the incumbents for that role and maybe stick with someone," Ten Doeschate said at a press conference on Thursday. While both Sudharsan and Padikkal have been getting long rope at nets, Ten Doeschate didn't want to spill the beans about the one who would make it. On the day, during slip formation, Padikkal was seen standing alongside KL Rahul and skipper Shubman Gill. After Rahul went to the nets, Sudharsan came in.

During nets, Sudharsan once again lost the grip on his bat which slipped and flew backwards like it happened in IPL twice.

"It's a difficult position to bat in and a very important position to bat. Dev comes in with



a ton of runs in domestic cricket across all the formats and obviously Sai's been high on runs in IPL with Gujarat, so they're both in good form.

"Whoever plays they'll be given a bit of a run. That's quite difficult with one Test match now, and then we don't play a Test match for another two months, and then we play two Test matches, and then you don't play for a while. So, you know, we need to factor that in," Ten Doeschate said citing a practical problem.

However he maintained that one needs

to quickly decide and continue with the person of choice. "The main point around there is we want to make a decision and then trust that person to grow into the role, and ideally quickly. Where we find ourselves in the WTC table? It's probably something we could have done better leading up to this is maybe backing someone in a different spot."

Siraj looks, fine assures Dutch coach: While there were reports about Mohammed Siraj's workload management, Hyderabad fast bowler looked in fine rhythm at nets. (PTI)

In Suthar versus Dubey, spin great Ashwin has his eyes on latter

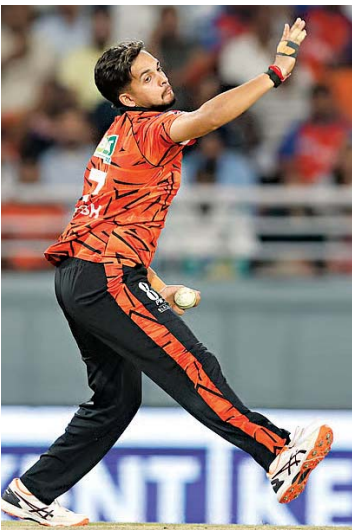
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

India spin great R Ashwin is looking forward to left-arm spinner Harsh Dubey making his debut in the one-off Test against Afghanistan beginning in Mullanpur on Saturday following the rookie's recent domestic exploits. It could be a toss up between uncapped Manav Suthar and Dubey with Kuldeep Yadav and Washington Sundar expected to feature in the playing eleven.

"My eyes will be on Harsh Dubey. I am curious whether he will get a chance. We will have to wait and see if team goes with Manav Suthar or Harsh Dubey. But I am particularly interested in Dubey because of his strong domestic season.

"He also had a very good IPL season. Those performances work in his favour. I am looking forward to seeing him make his debut," Ashwin told JioStar. Kuldeep too would be keen to perform after an ordinary IPL for Delhi Capitals.

"Kuldeep Yadav will lead the spin attack against Afghanistan in the absence of Ravindra Jadeja. He has been bowling with great rhythm and confidence. His ability to turn the ball both ways and his experi-



ence in home conditions make him a huge threat.

"Washington Sundar will play supporting role. He is more of a defensive, containing bowler who can also bat lower down the order. His accuracy and ability to bowl long spells will be useful on a wearing track. Both will be key to India's success in this Test match," added Ashwin.

Sports ministry launches cycle friendly campus certification



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

The Sports Ministry on Thursday said it has introduced a certification system for cycle-friendly institutions or cycle-only campuses and the likes of National Defence Academy and the Indian Military Academy will be felicitated for their "sustainable mobility practices" here on Sunday. The felicitation will take place during the 'Sundays on Cycle' event to be held in Delhi and other cities across

the country. Minister of State for Defence Sanjay Seth will join the event in Ranchi, while West Bengal's new Sports Minister Nisith Pramanik will participate in Kolkata.

Cricketer and Rajya Sabha MP Harbhajan Singh has appealed to people in Punjab to join the movement. In Delhi, noted film actor Vikrant Massey will participate in the event. More than 3.5 lakh registrations have already been received for cycling this Sunday under the FIT India campaign, the ministry stated.

Jaismine climbs to top rank in World Boxing rankings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ New Delhi

Reigning world champion Jaismine Lamboria climbed to the top of the women's 57kg rankings, while Asian championships gold medalists Priya Ghanghas (60kg) and Vishvanath Suresh (50kg) broke into the top three of their respective categories in the latest World Boxing rankings. Indian boxers featured in the top 10 across nine of the 10 women's weight categories and eight of the 10 men's divisions.

In the women's section, Minakshi retained her World No. 1 ranking in the 48kg category, while Preeti Pawar jumped five places to third in the 54kg weight class.



Jaismine, who won the silver at the Asian Championships earlier this year, moved up a spot to be the top ranked boxer in her weight class.

World Cup medallists Arundhati Choudhary (70kg), Pooja Rani (80kg) and Nupur (+80kg) were all ranked second in their respective divisions.

Pant trying too much, should control strokes: Sharma

SUMAN RAY ■ New Delhi

India wicketkeeper-batter Rishabh Pant is playing too many horizontal shots and throwing his wickets away, according to his formative coach Devender Sharma, who has advised him to play more vertical and more on the off-side. Pant had a forgettable IPL for the second season in a row following which he stepped down from captaincy of Lucknow Super Giants. He has also now become a one format player for India and recently lost his vice-captaincy in the Test team.

"He is trying too much and mostly playing horizontal shots. He is pushing & forcing himself too much. He should play more vertical shots that will give him more success.

"I will tell him to play a



"When I last talked to him, I had suggested him to play more vertical shots to get back into form. When you are not getting runs, you need to get back to basics," Sharma told PTI on Thursday.

Pant will be next in action in the one off Test against Afghanistan beginning in Mullanpur on June 6.

little differently with a different approach as there is a lot of difference in Test & T20 cricket. Last time when he played Test for India, he played a match winning innings. I am sure he will do it again against Afghanistan," said the Sonnet coach.

"He should show controlled aggression. He should concentrate more.

The problem is that he has too many strokes (shots) backfoot, frontfoot. He must cut down on his innovative shots. He should play more on the off-side rather than on the on-side," he observed. Sharma pointed out that it was just a matter of time that Pant returned to form. "Rishabh is a mentally strong cricketer. After the car accident, when he went to England, he scored centuries in both innings of a Test match. It's a big thing for a cricketer.

"I have seen him since childhood and groomed him. Whatever matches he played after accident, he played well. IPL is a white ball game. He had lean patch there. It comes in every big cricketer's career. Ups and downs come in every cricketer's life," he said. (PTI)

Rashid Khan may play Tests again: Shahidi

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mullanpur

Rashid Khan has done extremely well in the six Tests that he has played but he donning the whites again for Afghanistan is something between him and the national selectors, skipper Hashmatullah Shahidi said ahead of one-off game against India.

Shahidi, by far Afghanistan's best Test batter with two double hundreds and a healthy average of 48 plus, also spoke about how their nation needs to play more red ball games to measure up with the best.

"Rashid has done well in the Tests (45 wickets in 6 Tests) that he has played. Personally I haven't spoken to Rashid about whether he would play Test again or not. He had discussions with selectors and I don't want to talk about that," Shahidi



said at a press conference on Thursday.

However, he did concede that playing two Tests a year on an average has been the bane for Afghan cricket since they made their debut in 2018.

"We played India in 2018. We have more experience now but we need to play more to build our Test team. When it comes to domestic

cricket, we play six to seven red ball games but Tests, we get only one or two games a year," Shahidi sounded practical yet helpless about the situation.

When asked if the best talent in Afghanistan only want to make a career out of franchise based T20 leagues, Shahidi begged to differ.

"Everyone knows that our guys do very well in franchise leagues and if you see our white ball performances have been good. But even then, we have a lot of talent in Afghanistan who are waiting for their chance," said Shahidi.

He has no complaints about the pitch and the scorching heat in Mullanpur.

"We had a camp in Jalalabad in Afghanistan and also played a tournament. Temperature was 35 degrees there so we are well equipped to handle the heat," he said.

Indian men's hockey team braces for Pakistan challenge in U-18 Asia Cup

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Kakamigahara (Japan)

The Indian men's hockey team will look to address its weaknesses when it faces Pakistan, while the women's side will aim to continue its dominant run against China in the semifinals of the U-18 Asia Cup here on Friday.

The Indian U-18 men's hockey team finished second in Pool A with three wins and one defeat. India scored 32 goals and conceded only six during their campaign so far.

The men's side opened the tournament with a commanding 13-0 victory against Kazakhstan before suffering a 2-4 defeat against hosts Japan. They responded strongly with a 4-1 win over Korea, followed by a comprehensive 13-1 victory against Chinese Taipei to book their



place in the semifinals.

Captain Ketan Kushwaha leads the scoring charts for India with seven goals, while Ashish Tani Puri has scored six goals. Gazeer Khan and Shahrukh Ali have contributed three goals each.

Pakistan, on the other hand, topped Pool B with two wins and one defeat from their three matches.

"After playing four

matches, we have identified the areas where we need to improve, especially penalty corner attack and defence," Indian U-18 men's team coach Sardar Singh said.

"We have been working on these areas in separate groups with the defenders, midfielders, and forwards to ensure we are fully prepared," he added.